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Teen And Up Audiences

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Shadow World

by Dagron

Summary

Adora and Catra are presumed dead, missing, in a world that has ended. Horde Prime never got his hands on the Heart of Etheria. Instead, something far more sinister has taken hold of him. In a world wrapped in shadows, what remains of the Princess alliance strives to find a shred of hope in the darkness that has become Etheria... Glimmer and Bow are determined to set things right.

Notes

Happy Anniversary of SPOP Season 5's release. Yeay!

The first chapter of this is fairly short - but do expect following chapters to grow in length. Also be prepared for sad feels... I am aiming for a happy ending, I promise.

Lost in the Dark

Her grip tightens on Adora's shoulder. The girl is weak, distracted, but her power is still there, just barely accessible as Shadow Weaver reaches out with her magic. Her hair stands on end as she raises her free hand, physically tasting the energy of the Heart from where they stand. Soon...

A scream echoes. Adora tries to lurch away, the other girl's name on her lips like a mantra. But Shadow Weaver doesn't release her. She fears, for a brief instant, that Adora will strong arm her away, and she does try. Horde Prime's corruption has robbed Shadow Weaver's former ward of her trademark physical strength. The girl stumbles, and Shadow Weaver's clawed fingers dig deeper into Adora's upper arm. The blonde whimpers, in pain, but it doesn't matter. The only thing that matters is releasing the magic. Yes.

The hunger in Shadow Weaver grows and flares. Shadow Weaver yells as she feels it tear through her. The world turns to darkness.

She feeds. And it still isn't enough.

Lost in the Dark

A tiny spark flies in the wind, brighter by far than any of the moons looming above. It's a clear night, and the stars are twinkling, just about there if you take the time to look up and stare hard. No one bothers to look up any more. The sparkle glints and twinkles as it moves in little jumps, giving the impression of several sparks appearing in quick sequence. Shadows recoil from its approach as it dives through the branches of the Whispering Woods. A hint of colour seems to reappear in the world as it leaves the greyed-out valley behind. Green leaves

and pink vines greet the spark as it lands on a mushroom that glows momentarily on contact. Then the spark bounces off, growing in an instant to reveal the presence of a young woman, glitter evaporating off her form as she sighs and droops her shoulders. It's been a long and tiresome day, and Queen Glimmer needs respite dearly. She knocks upon the frame of knotted wood as she pushes through the cream-coloured curtain of Madame Razz's home.

"Glimmer, you're back!" Bow is sat next to the hammock, watching over the form sleeping there. His bright smile and broad shoulders are a sight for sore eyes, coated in the warm hues from Razz's fireplace and his voice carries a warmth that is all his own.

"Hey," Glimmer whispers, wishing she had the energy to fly across the room into his arms. Instead, she crosses the space slowly, scanning the area before asking, "Where's Razz?"

"She left an hour ago with her broom saying something about dusting down the doors to the Crystal Castle. Razz was muttering about how the berries haven't been tasting right." Glimmer gives a half-hearted chuckle at the extent of Razz's worries. Bow's gaze turns serious. "How's the Moon Stone holding up?"

"It's still untouched," Glimmer replies, sitting down beside him before flinging herself back into the cushions on the ledge. It's tight quarters for four sharing, but Razz's generosity has allowed Bow and Glimmer the peace of mind to rest that they haven't been able to find anywhere else in almost a year. Something about Razz's cottage and the magic of the woods has kept it mostly untouched from the cataclysm that is eating away at the rest of the world. They'd feel guilty about putting the old woman at risk if Razz hadn't amply demonstrated her uncanny knack for keeping the shadows away when she took them in. Glimmers sighs deeply. "I just don't get it. Shadow Weaver or whatever that monster calls herself these days is draining anything magical that her shadows can get their hands on, swallowing Mystacor sorcerers whole, and yet... All the Rune Stones seem untouched?

Why, Bow? Why?"

"I don't know, Glimmer," he responds, his hand warm on hers as he turns to her. "But we'll figure it out. Together."

They share a soft smile together, eyes sad at the state of the world, but glad that they still have each other. Glimmer sits back up, wrapping herself around Bow's torso as he wraps his arms around her shoulders, tight, just how she likes it. The woman in the hammock stirs, but doesn't wake. Bow's lips quirk into a grin.

"I still can't believe we found *her*," he whispers, voice in awe.

Glimmer smiles, looking at the face of the person resting next to them. The woman had been weak when they found her, moments away from being devoured by the Shadows. Recovery has been a slow process. Still, it lights a beacon of hope in Glimmer's heart.

"Told you I felt her presence," she says, holding onto Bow's hand as she leans in under his chin. Her gaze is fond as she reaches with her free hand to brush some locks of hair off of the woman's face. She'd felt her warm encouragement reaching her on the day the world ended. She'd felt it again a few times since, giving her the confidence boost she needed to win a desperate battle or even just when she felt like giving up, exhausted and afraid as she thought back on how much they'd lost. The woman stirs once more, blinking as her eyes adjust to the soft light in the room. The lilac in her gaze turns to meet Glimmer's, and the woman smiles, her mouth attempting to form words but no sound coming out. Glimmer whispers a gentle greeting, her hand moving to rest against her mother's cheek. "Hey mum."

"I'll go grab some broth," Bow says, dropping a kiss to Glimmer's brow. He's giving the two a moment together, and the young queen appreciates him all the more for it. She can already tell that Angella is brimming with questions that she cannot physically ask. The need to resort to slate and chalk is frustrating and embarrassing enough to the former Queen without any unnecessary onlookers. Angella managed to explain a little of

what she's been through since she got trapped in the portal, but the slate is too small and her energy too depleted to answer all the questions Glimmer has. Glimmer hands her the slate and chalk with a teasing quip and eyeroll reminiscent of simpler days.

It's peaceful and cosy. The three while away the time before Razz returns, a large basket full of berries on her arm that Glimmer eagerly helps her unload. Bow shares a laugh with Angella as Razz baps Glimmer on the head with her broom and shows her the proper way to roll the dough. It's almost enough to help them forget the shadows outside. But only almost.

A New Hope.

Chapter Summary

> The Crystal Castle still holds some secrets as Bow gets in touch with other Rebellion agents, hoping for good news.

The default First One's hologram phases into being in the now dark corridor, her presence the only source of light as she observes the crumpled form beneath her.

"She-Ra currently incapacitated. Please relocate to recuperation chamber." The voice intones, with only a minor glitch running through the interface. A mechanical spider, its eyes glowing a soft blue, muted somehow, approaches and grasps at the prone form. The robotic guardian manages to lift the body gently, a faint hiss of breath escaping as they start backing away the way they came. The hologram vanishes, before reappearing in a large chamber further along. The giant first one's guardian there has collapsed, black smoke belching from its limbs, sections of its body glitching as broken code appears to run over it. It no longer flashes green, but it is clear that it is no longer able to function.

"The Guardian of the Heart chamber is terminally compromised," the Hologram says, lifting her hand with her palm out towards it. The Guardian's wyrm-like body dissolves into nothing. "Guardian no longer required."

The Hologram pauses. A prone form is splayed out where the Guardian was moments before. Dark pools surround the body, many deep gashes obvious to the naked eye, even in the half-light of the Hologram's presence. The Hologram stares. The protocol for how to handle this situation takes a lot longer to run.

Without saying a word, she summons another spider.

A New Hope.

A wooden thud on the Castle's outer walls isn't normally heard in its inner chambers. It sounds once, twice, then three times. Something reacts. It's small at first, a faint whirring through the walls, the soft shimmer of First One's code. The echoes of the thumps have long faded by the time the whirring grows louder, resolving itself into a faint hiss and crackle.

"... repairs currently at... three percent... – ready to run in..." The voice is tinny, monotonous. It does not rush. There are long gaps before it repeats the same message, several iterations before the increments mentioned change. The lighting in the room is faint, its glow ebbing and flowing up the walls to a rhythm not unlike a slow heartbeat.

A week has passed, the Crystal Castle's default interface phases into the room. Her glow lights up the three plinths there. All are occupied.

"... 'ty-nine percent... – ready... week..." The Hologram turns to the wall with the most glistening lines. She raises her hands and the writing glows brighter. Empowered, the voice grows louder.

"Light Hope Artificial Intelligence repairs successfully in progress. Next update in one hour." The voice from the walls finishes. The hissing and crackling ceases, instead replaced with the steady sound of heartbeats.

The Hologram hovers over one of the plinths.
"She-Ra remains stable. Light Hope reactivation shall enable proper healing procedures to run."

The Hologram does not check the other plinths, though all three are glowing with similar hues, lines of glowing First One's code intermittently run across them and their occupants. The Hologram

disappears.

The rhythm of the heartbeat sounds seems to change upon the latest mention of Light Hope. It's slight. But it's there.

"Come in Sea Hawk, are you there?" Bow taps the side of his tracking pad willing away the noise mucking up the signal. He's sat in his fathers' library, having found a quiet nook to hide in. The building is a lot more crowded than it has ever been. All his brothers and their assorted families are there. Lance is running himself ragged trying to provide for them all, and George has a deep scowl etching itself onto his face. Thankfully, several of his brothers are going out of their way to lessen the disruption to their parents' lives, but nothing can stop the scared mutterings of their partners or the awkward questions asked by the young ones. Bow is just glad that they are all healthy and safe from the monsters taking over their homes. "Seahawk! Come on..."

Finally, after a tense moment when the device emits a worrying whistle, his moustachioed friend's face appears. Correction, his now bearded friend's face appears. It doesn't look like the man's preferred choice of appearance, but at least he's not trying to shave with his energy sabre any more.
"Seahawk, there you are!" Bow is ecstatic to finally make contact.

"Ah Bow, my good friend!" Seahawk's smile doesn't come as easy as it used to, but he holds it nonetheless. "Good to see you. I see we-" He interrupts himself with a frown. Seahawk opens his mouth to continue, pauses and waits again before he finally speaks again. "I see we have a delay on the line again." There's a sad slump to the sailor's shoulders as he leans back. Bow tries to make out as much as he can of the man's surroundings. Wooden beams, faint scorch marks... A boat, possibly?

"Where are you?" Bow asks, preparing himself for the ordeal of a

conversation with nearly half a minute's delay. Ever since the shadows appeared, long distance communication has become rough. There must be a frequency the magic shadows emit messing with the tech. He hasn't managed to find a workaround yet, and teleporting with Glimmer to their location on the regular is risky with how quick the shades are to sniff out magic users. They had to walk to the library, not the ideal choice with a weakened Angella insisting to come with. Luckily, they found an abandoned skiff about halfway that he managed to get running again.

"We're currently sailing, in disguise!" Bow chooses not to ask as Seahawk elaborates, "along the large river that winds through Plumeria's territory. How about you and the delightful Glimmer, my good friend? I see you have surrounded yourself with books once more. Research?"

Bow chuckles, hurrying to reply before his often-impatient friend can start on a tangent. Thankfully they have become well-practiced at handling delays in the conversation.
"I'm at my Dads' library, yeah," Bow winces upon hearing the noise of pottery breaking, followed by the upset crying of one of his nieces or nephews. "We're hiding out in the Whispering Woods just now. We're looking into why none of the Rune Stones seem to be targeted by the shadows." He pauses a moment, before deciding the sooner it's said the better, and adds, "we also have big news. We've found Angella."

Thanks to the delay, Bow gets to watch every single reaction on Seahawk's face as the news sinks in. When his half-worded responses stop and he stands, shouting for his travel companions, Bow chuckles and prepares himself to leave the refuge of his nook, if only momentarily.

After a chaotic moment of the tablet on the other side changing hands, Bow is confronted with the intensity of Netossa's gaze, Seahawk and Perfuma both crowding over her shoulders.
"What's this about you finding Angella?" Netossa's tone is sharp

and no nonsense, as expected.

Bow doesn't wait to step out into the library area that Glimmer and Angella are occupying. He points the tracking pad's camera at the two, and takes a moment to watch them hanging out together. It's very different to how it used to be before Angella's untimely departure, but there's a connection between the two that reminds Bow of when he first met Glimmer. She used to share everything with her mother. His girlfriend is chatting away, waving around the book in her hands as she probably rants on about magical theory and wishing Casta were there to help it make sense. Angella listens to her patiently, nodding with a smile as her eyes keep reading the book in front of her. She pauses a moment to point out a section of text. Glimmer's reaction clearly flusters Angella, and there's a moment that sends a pang straight to Bow's heart, as the two play-wrestle. It's been six months since they lost Adora, but Bow doesn't think any of them will ever get over it.

"No way!" "Oh, by the Heart-Blossom, it is her!" "Now this is a tale I've got to hear!"

Hearing the reaction of the other three, Bow takes it as his cue to return to the nook, just in time to avoid one of his brothers barging through him with a fresh pile of books for the table.

"It's a long story," Bow ends up saying, "but for now all you need to know is that she's alive, she's with us, and she's recuperating. What about you? Any news of the other Princesses?"

After a noticeable delay, Bow can see Seahawk raising his hand ready to start an elaborate account. Normally he wouldn't mind, but with the delay being what it is, he is glad Netossa is the one holding the pad. The woman, who wears a hat now that her undercut is growing out, swiftly interrupts Seahawk with a sharp gesture.
"The reason we're currently traveling through Plumeria in a boat, as I'm sure Seahawk has mentioned, is because Shadow Prime, as

she's taken to calling herself now, has doubled down on efforts to take over Plumeria using both Clones and chipped Princesses."
There's a choked noise that Bow realises is from Perfuma. Netossa's dark eyes remain serious as her brow twitches in frustration. "The lovely Mermista," the sarcastic delivery is clearly for Seahawk's benefit, "has been turning the area surrounding the Heart-Blossom into true marshland. The kingdom is impassable except for a few inlets that Shadow-Clones guard around the clock. I think she's turning the heart of the Kingdom into a food store exclusively for her use."

Oh, that is very concerning. Bow frowns. Food shortages are becoming a more and more pressing issue as the lack of proper daylight and the damage wrought by the shades interferes more and more with provision. Stores are already running low. Fields immediately adjacent to the Heart-Blossom have been resilient, but not having access to them promises for a lot of hungry mouths.
"How are Casta, Spinnerella and Frosta handling things with the main refugee groups?" He asks, hoping to hear good news.

He spies the notification on his device informing him that he needs to end the communication soon. The Shades and Shadow-clones have been noticeably bad at handling tech, but he doesn't want to try their luck. They still have no information on what became of Entrapta.

Thankfully, Netossa makes it relatively quick, likely spotting a similar warning on her end.
"They're handling it... For now. Spinny's... Spinny took a hit last time Huntara's gangs led an assault on them, but it's nothing they can't handle." Ah, that explained Netossa's sour mood. There's a short pause before Netossa adds, "Can we rendezvous? At the old hidden cave in three days time? We need to talk over strategy properly."

It's risky, the location being known by Shadow Weaver as a former Rebellion base, but in the several times they've checked

the location since, it has been blissfully free of magic shadows.
"Sure," he nods. "Meet you at that base in three days time. Stay safe!" He doesn't wait for their reply before cutting off. Bow looks forward to these check-ins. He misses their friends, but every check-in comes with harsh reminders of the reality they now live in. Anytime more than two Magic users get together, it's asking for trouble. Large populations are being displaced or made subservient; their well-being threatened without rhyme nor reason. Hearing what is happening to Plumeria... It's...

Bow sighs, putting the tracker pad away in his bag. He needs a moment before he heads back out to continue helping Glimmer and Angella with their research. He's just closed his eyes when he hears the curtain to the nook rattle.

"Hey," it's Glimmer's voice, quiet as it so often is since her rescue from the Horde Prime's vessel. "Are you okay?"
Bow looks up at her before shaking his head. Her hands reach for him before the tears even start falling. She presses his head to her chest, running her hands through his hair in a way she knows he finds soothing.

"Don't worry, I think mum has found something," she whispers. "It's a start."

Reawaken

Chapter Summary

Light Hope reawakens. This draws some attention.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

For one blissful moment, Micah feels cleansed. The dark magic pouring out of him evaporates in the light bursting forth from his daughter, as she fights back. She is every bit the strong woman he hoped she would grow up to become and more. He even, for a moment, imagines he catches a glimpse of Angella in the brightness shrouding her. It feels like coming home.

And then his whole world goes dark.

The next time Micah is conscious; he is faced with Horde Prime. He still has no control over his actions, the chip at the back of his neck itching uncomfortably as his body stands stoically in front of the alien. Something is clearly wrong though. Horde Prime's eyes are no longer the sickly green that had been poisoning Micah's veins with his dogma, but a sinister red. The bleached hues of Horde Prime's skin are now ashen, coated in shadows... No, not shadows, but Shadow Magic. Dark Magic. How?

And then Horde Prime opens his mouth, and Micah knows, without a doubt, who it is talking.

Reawaken

"Light Hope Artificial Intelligence successfully repaired. Preparing to reboot in 3, 2, 1..."

The room brightens, a soft blue hue bringing clarity to the space as an orb of light starts spinning in the centre. The Castle's default AI appears, observing the process. The walls intone more progress updates as the orb changes colours, its shape fluctuating. Finally, the voice declares the reboot complete, and the orb shimmers, shifting into the shape of the AI known as Light Hope.

The tall figure's face remains blank of expression as she opens her eyes.
"I am Light Hope," she stares into the distance a moment. "Reviewing memory banks... How long was I out of functioning order?"

The default AI responds to the tune of over a year. Light Hope frowns.
"Accessing Crystal Castle systems, loading updates on all key parameters," she says, waiting a moment before smiling at the graphs appearing before her. "Readings from the Heart Chamber report that it has been successfully fired: no energy build-up remains. Good."

She steps down from the central podium, raising her hand to dismiss the graphs and the default AI before raising the hand higher above her head. Her voice takes on an echo as her body shimmers.
"The Heart of Etheria project to be marked as complete. Heart Update to the Light Hope system can now be uninstalled." She clicks her fingers, the black markings across her torso vanishing to reveal a simple white diamond shape in their stead. She sighs, before smiling again, gentler this time, seemingly at peace.

Light Hope turns to observe the plinths beside her. Only she is not the only one doing the observing... One of the bodies on the plinths is no longer reclining on their back, instead turned over,

pushing themselves up onto one elbow. There's a disbelieving crease to their brow, a wary squint to their gaze. Their voice when they speak is weak, but Light Hope would still recognize it anywhere.

"Light Hope... Is that... Is that you?"

"Hello Mara. There is much we must speak about." Light Hope, somehow, kneels, her expression kind as she places her hand next to Mara's on the crystal plinth. "You have been gone a long time."

The meeting at the hidden cave in the mountains takes some time to prepare for. Bow and Glimmer thank Razz for her hospitality as they pack a tent and some supplies onto the rescued skiff, while Angella uses her latest burst of energy to write down more of her theories in preparation. Razz, as usual, mutters something incomprehensible but somehow deep, insisting that they wait long enough for her to make them a pie to go.

When, finally, they set off with Bow at the wheel - or whatever you call the guiding stick on a Horde Skiff - he can spy out of the corner of his eye Angella making some amused hand gestures at Glimmer. Glimmer's flustered "Mum!" in response is all he needs to know that the book George gave them is proving useful in bridging some of the communication gaps. He shakes his head and smiles. It'll be his turn to read up on the hand signals when they make camp for the night. For now, he needs to safely navigate their transport through the gnarled roots and branches of the whispering woods, to the nearby lake where they'd agreed that Glimmer would initiate a group teleport. It's far enough from Razz's cottage to keep the old lady safe, and remote enough from any civilian encampments that they shouldn't have any fear of being ambushed.

He's fully focused on the twists and turns required when Glimmer taps his shoulder. He can't afford the distraction, needing to keep his eyes on the compass so they don't veer too far off-track.

"What is it Glimmer?" He asks, sharply. He fears for a moment that she's spotted a shade, or worse, a clone.

"Bow... The Beacon!" Glimmer's voice is shrill. "The Beacon from the Crystal Castle, it's lit!"

That gets his attention. He pulls on the brakes, wincing when Angella lets out a disgruntled huff at being jostled from her nap. Sure enough, when he turns to look where Glimmer is pointing, he recognises the light splitting through the heavens. Hope, unbidden, stirs in his chest.

"Do you think that Adora..." Glimmer's whisper, breathless as it is, is too much for Bow to process right now.

"We can't-" He takes a breath, wills the squeak in his voice away. "We can't presume. And we can't afford the diversion with the others on their way to meet us."

"Not even a small one?" Glimmer's sparkly and hopeful gesture pulls at Bow's heart strings, but he forces himself to give her a flat-eyed stare.

"Glimmer," he puts a gentle hand on her arm. She sags as they both notice the beacon going out, the sky returning to its enduring darkness. Bow pauses before he continues. "We checked every inch of that building we could reach at the first opportunity. There were no signs of either Adora or even Catra. Just..."

"I know, I know..." The heartbreak in Glimmer's voice tears at Bow's soul. "Just a crazy amount of dry blood on the floor and a whole lot of dark rooms... when the damned place didn't start throwing Spiders at us!"

She's clinging to him, a familiar upset on her features and he doesn't know what he can do to fix things. He deeply wants to believe that the two girls are still out there, alive and well, but...

A knocking sound draws their attention. Angella rolls her eyes at them, lifting her knuckles from the box she'd been banging on to gesture a number of signs at them. Glimmer sniffs and nods as Bow looks to her for a translation. She hiccups a little before obliging.
"Mum's saying... We can go back, afterwards."

Bow turns back to the former queen of Brightmoon with a grateful smile. "You're right. Once we've met up with the others, we can go back and investigate. Whatever caused the Crystal Castle's beacon to light up will still be worth investigating then."

Angella nods, satisfied, before making a sign that needs no translation as she snuggles back into her cocoon of blankets. With a nod, Bow obliges, moving the skiff back onto the track.

They've got a long day ahead of them. Glimmer's going to teleport them a day's walk away from the cave entrance, so they have time to speed away from their emergence point and scout out the surrounding area. If the last year has taught them anything, it's that you can never be too careful.

From his perch in the now deserted Brightmoon Palace, Micah watches the horizon with practiced boredom. When not actively calling upon his talents, Shadow Prime is blessedly lax compared to her predecessor. Provided he doesn't go against the main prerogatives of the Sorceress's ill-gotten rule, he only needs to tune out the unpleasant whispers that serve as the background noise to their neural link. The decade he lost to Beast Island allows him a lot more resilience than some of his more unfortunate fellow captives. He winces a little, thinking back to the breakdown he had witnessed, back in the Fright Zone. The Scorpion Princess, he thinks, he didn't catch her name... He couldn't help as the magic hijacking his nervous system channelled dark magic at the Black Garnet. He couldn't reach out when the Princess's red lightning flared and she screamed. It was hard to tell whether it had been a genuine attempt to absorb the

Rune Stone's powers or a punishment for the one born to channel them. It was... difficult.

All that is left of Shadow Weaver now, as far as Micah can tell, is the parasitical hunger he recalls from the spell of attainment... and the same dark whispers that had driven a number of his classmates to despair when she'd been Light Spinner, hiding her abuse from prying eyes with smiling eyes and gentle hands. There is no patience in her commands now, no caution without someone to overrule her ambition. It is very different from Horde Prime, Micah finds.

Horde Prime's presence in his mind had been large, looming, and absolute. Where Shadow Prime speaks in falsely sweet tones and vicious whispers, Prime had been direct and confident, but ever watchful. He had millennia of practice at controlling the minds of thousands, and you could tell... Shadow Weaver, in contrast, had always been one to focus her energies on just a few pawns.

It's a glaring weakness, he thinks. There's a short-sightedness to her strategy that Micah doesn't understand. There is no sign of the ruthless researcher who showed him how to unlock secrets of magic no one before her had even considered. In his experience, Shadow Weaver liked to always plan three steps ahead. Now...

He sees, in the distance, a light piercing through the shadows. A beacon of blue and lilac hue, shooting up from within the depths of the Whispering Woods. Some of Shadow Prime's lingering watchful shades perk up. They twist and swirl as they come to stand next to him, observing the phenomena and then recoiling. Two of them whisk themselves away, clearly gone to inform their mistress. It'll be a while before she responds. She has a network of linked and subservient minds at her disposal, but, still, she only trusts her magic shadows first and foremost. She foregoes the ability to have underlings immediately inform her of events of interest unless it is to do with her current fixation. Micah watches as the light dies out, unsure what could have caused it. He'll go get cleaned up and grab some food. Maybe he'll even get the

chance at a nice long nap. After that, he'll probably have his marching orders as the closest fighting unit in Shadow Prime's arsenal.

Micah hopes. Whatever the beam of light was, whatever caused it, maybe that'll be the help he needs to finally break free.

Chapter End Notes

> Currently chipping away at chapter 6. Hope to keep a good writing pace going. Would love to hear any thoughts or theories you have. :D

Warding

Chapter Summary

Enter Castaspella...

Time doesn't pass when you are stuck inside a closed portal. Angella learns this the hard way, falling from the heavens onto a grassy field in a world that no longer resembles the one she left.

She's heard of stars, of course, but to see them is something else. She caught a glimpse of them while chasing after Adora in the false reality. If it weren't for the fact that she saw that world dissolving beneath her as she dropped the sword into Adora's hands, Angella might think she's been returned to it. Etheria feels wrong. Her ability to draw on the powers of the Moonstone is severed, though she can still sense them: burning, boiling, sparking far too bright. Somewhere, she can tell, her daughter is hurting.

Angella goes to spread her wings, only to find that they can't carry her anymore. She drops back onto the ground. Looking up, she can see dark shadows begin to blot out the stars. And then...

She can't sense Glimmer anymore.

Warding

When Glimmer appears out of the blue, Castaspella is mid-enchantment. Her focus breaks, and the spell circle shatters onto the floor. She forces herself to take a deep calming breath. It's been a very rough week. Still, Casta is never one to pass up on an opportunity to hug her favourite niece, even if she does have the worst timing.

"Glimmer. What brings you here?" The young queen squeaks as Casta's embrace becomes maybe a touch too tight. Casta quickly releases her to readjust her hair.

Glimmer, as always, is never one to beat about the bush.
"Hi, Aunt Casta. We need you at our strategy meeting. Like now. Please?" Casta's niece looks up to her with a very familiar expression. Castaspella could never refuse Micah anything when he pulled that look. Still, as Head Sorceress of the (sadly currently occupied) floating city of Mystacor and as the current leader for this group of refugees, she cannot just up and leave at a moment's notice... Especially not with Shadow Weaver's blasted shades circling at every opportunity. Casta sighs.

"Look, I need to set-up some wards and talk to Spinnerella and our lookouts. Keeping people safe is our number one priority." Moons above, Casta misses being able to knit her stress away. She points at the various locations around the encampment she's been setting up wards in and starts walking. "If you help me set up the wards, I can be ready to go sooner, but it'll have to be a short meeting. With Spinnerella on bedrest and the gangs from the Crimson Wastes crowding us, I really can't afford to be away for long."

Glimmer has the grace to look a little sheepish as she pulls at the hem of her cloak.
"How is Spinnerella? Bow mentioned she got hurt, but he didn't have any details." Glimmer follows Casta's lead as she gestures for them to stop and starts drawing another circle of power in the air. As expected, Glimmer is following with ease and is producing a ward of a quality that Castaspella is a little envious of. Having to renew the wards daily has really been draining. She's just glad that the group she was watching with Frosta are self-sufficient and currently hidden enough for her to be able to switch over to support the injured Wind Princess. If only so many of her Sorcerers hadn't been chipped under Prime... But Casta is quick to shut that line of thinking down. That way lies heartbreak and grief.

"It's mostly her old ankle wound playing up, thank goodness. A lucky hit in Shadow-Huntara's last raid."

Castaspella marches them around the camp, and the wards are bolstered in half the time. They catch up a bit, mostly talking about Bow and Glimmer's latest efforts to find a way to put a stop to the Shadow Invasion.
"Really? None of the Rune Stones, despite being undefended, are being sapped?" Castaspella's sigil wavers a bit at hearing that. Shadow Weaver's magic has certainly not been shy about devouring regular magic casters. The rage in Casta's heart hammers through her veins. Glimmer's gentle touch on her arm helps her to refocus on her task.

Mere moments later, the two approach the medical tent to find Spinnerella. She looks beat. Her colour is off and dark bruises are visible beneath her eyes. Her weak ankle is sat on a pile of folded clothes for lack of spare cushions. The bandage on it is thick. Casta sees Glimmer wincing out of the corner of her eye.

"That's the wards all refreshed, they should keep out all but the strongest of shades for now." Castaspella clasps her hands around Glimmer's shoulders and gives her niece a gentle shake. "This one has come to whisk me away for a strategy meeting, will you all be alright without me for a bit? How long will you need me for, Glimmer?"

The faint grimace on her niece's face doesn't reassure Castaspella at all. She forces herself to picture a nice beach, a good yarn to knit, peace and quiet. It feels more and more like a lifetime ago.

"We hope to keep it short," Glimmer says in her most diplomatic voice. "It just depends on how much you can help for what we've come up with."

"It must be quite important for you to have teleported right into the camp," Spinnerella says. She's smiling, clearly not too worried.

She waves Glimmer over to give her a quick embrace. "It is good to see you in person. It has been far too long. How is Bow doing?"

"He's holding up okay," Glimmer says, embracing Spinnerella back tightly before standing tall. "We also found..."

"You found...?" Casta prompts, curious at seeing Glimmer hesitate.

"We also found Mum."

"Angella?" Spinnerella barely has the time to ask before Castaspella is grabbing Glimmer to turn her around.

"Why didn't you say so sooner!?"

Angella wakes up from her nap to the sounds of Bow chatting with Netossa, Perfuma, and a voice she doesn't immediately recognise. Blearily, she sits up and rubs her eyes. The unknown voice belongs to a young man whose face looks like Micah's used to when he'd take one of Angella's magic blasts to the face in a sparring match: charred remnants of beard, sparkling eyes. The red scarf and inclination to sing out various phrases match the description she has of Seahawk, so Angella relaxes. It is good to see that the three they came here to meet with managed to arrive safely... Well, as safely as the remnants of soot on them imply. Every time SeaHawk even mentions the word fire, Netossa sends him a dirty look while patting at her sizzled hair. Seahawk finally finishes the tale he is telling, involving, unsurprisingly, a boat being set aflame, when Bow finally notices that Angella is awake again.

"Oh hey," he says, giving a wave and then clumsily executing some of the hand signs they've been trying out. "You're awake! Glimmer's just away to fetch Casta and then we can start

whenever you're ready."

Angella nods. She's pulling her satchel to her side and retrieving her notes as Netossa comes closer. The Princess is a bit unsure, but clearly emotional.
"Bow mentioned you've been through a lot but... It's so good to see you again."

Angella feels her own eyes tearing up too as she pulls Netossa into a hug. Both Netossa and Spinnerella have been stalwart supports ever since the first Princess Alliance. They stayed by Angella's side even after their kingdoms were lost to the Horde, even after the rest of the Alliance left and when Micah... Angella didn't expect to feel this much upon seeing Netossa. She wants to tell her so, but the lump in her throat from her capture by rogue mages and then near obliteration by one of Shadow Weaver's shades still robs her of her words. A tight hug and meaningful eye contact will have to do for now. The sign book that Lance gave them doesn't really cover how to convey half of what she wants to express anyway.

Angella spots Bow fiddling awkwardly with his tracker pad and rolls her eyes.
"Your girlfriend will be fine," Netossa calls out, seeing where Angella's attention flitted to.

It still warms Angella's heart to think that while she was away Glimmer and Bow have confessed feelings for one another. She was never certain that they'd become an item, by the moons, she'd even thought Glimmer might end up with Adora for a while, but she's glad. They've both grown so much and she's so proud of them. She wishes she could have done more to help them before. She's here now though, and she intends to give it her all. Any knowledge her many years can bring to the table, any insight she has to offer shall be theirs.

Angella finishes setting up her prepared cards and diagrams, with Netossa helping near seamlessly thanks to her brilliant analytical

mind. Perfuma and Seahawk entertain each other as Bow is in the process of walking a trench into the floor from nerves. The faint twinkling of her daughter's teleport finally reaches their ears.

It's a delight every time she gets to see it: Glimmer, teleporting with full access to the powers of the Moon Stone. Angella now understands why her link to the Moon Stone felt off when she returned to Etheria. In her absence, Glimmer went through with her coronation, gaining access to the energy the Moon Stone previously reserved for Angella.

Still, Angella needs to brace before facing Castaspella. There's been tension between them two ever since Micah died and they never really understood each other before then... Angella has no doubt that her sacrifice in the Portal incident won't have endeared her to Castaspella, who by the sounds of it had to help Glimmer organise the transition through her grief.

Angella does not expect Casta to run up to her the minute her feet touch the ground. Castaspella does. Within seconds the smaller woman has Angella in a bone-crushing hug, sobbing in relief. Her rapid muttering seems to be nonsense at first as Angella tries to recover her balance. Only Angella does manage to catch some words that send her reeling to the floor.

What does Castaspella mean, when she says "if only Micah wasn't chipped"?!

Catra awakes with a gasp. Her insides are burning, she coughs, lashing out because the last thing she remembers is teeth, far too many teeth. She needs to... Adora. She needs to protect Adora, help her get to... She blinks. The green lighting... It's... It's gone. And something is holding onto her arm, but it feels like a hand, not a tentacle. Catra feels like her skin is buzzing as she turns her eyes to see who it is. Her claws extend further, fear thrumming

through her. She knows that it is neither Shadow Weaver nor Adora before she even looks upon the stranger; still, there is something familiar about them, even though Catra knows she has never met them. The smell of spaceships and flowers and some kind of spice, Catra thinks, as she looks upon the bronze skin and dark eyes. The woman's brown hair is tied in a braid high on her head and still reaches down to her hips, large gold ornamentation weighing it down. Catra feels light headed.

"Breathe," the woman says, her voice soft, her grip on Catra's wrist relaxing to gently take her hand. The woman demonstrates slow breaths in, slow breaths out, a soft smile on her face as Catra finds herself following the woman's lead. "You're okay, you are safe here."

"Ah, Catra," says a voice that Catra does recognise. She leaps to her feet, defensive stance at the ready despite the dizziness the move causes. There, behind the unknown woman, stands that darn Hologram. She doesn't seem to register the nature of Catra's response to her. "You are awake," it continues. "Good. You can help explain what has happened in my absence."

"Get away from me," Catra hisses, surprised at how rough her voice sounds. Her throat is dry. Her limbs ache and itch. She doesn't...

Wait, is that Adora?

The woman goes to talk to Catra, but the Hologram interrupts her wordlessly, the two watching as Catra leaps to the podium where Adora is lying. Catra's hands shake as she checks Adora's pulse. Adora's breathing is slow but steady. She's... She's sleeping.

"Adora... Adora... Wake up." Catra tries to shake her. Her hands are weak. She's noticing now the faint scarring on her own arms, the lights intermittently running over Adora's body... Just like at the crystal of Arxia. She glares up at the two other occupants of the room, baring her fangs. "What are you doing to her?"

The two share a look.
"Adora is healing," the Hologram - what was her name again? Light Hope? - responds. "She needs more rest before she is healed enough to wake."

The other woman steps forward, kneeling so that she is eye level with Catra, but still out of the immediate reach of her claws. "My name is Mara," she says, and Catra frowns at the name; it definitely sounds familiar. Mara's voice is soft as she looks over Adora. "I am... Was... She-Ra. The last She-Ra before Adora."

Yes. That makes sense. She-Ra... But something doesn't add up. Catra's emotions flare: the old cocktail of anger, hurt and confusion; but she bites her lip to refrain from lashing out. Mara looks... She looks lost, aggrieved.

"Adora means a lot to you, doesn't she?" Mara says, with a soft, sad tilt to her head.

"Everything," says Catra. It's a harsh, hoarse whisper, that echoes through the room. Feeling the warmth of Adora's limp hand in hers is the only thing grounding her. "I... What... What happened? I don't remember anything, after..."

"After...?"

A faint glow has appeared in the corner of Catra's eye, causing her to stare with terror trembling through her veins.

"Is that... Adora still has the Failsafe? How...?"

Mara scrambles at Catra's exclamation, her eyes wide as she too takes in the flickering light that has momentarily appeared atop Adora's breast.

"Is now a good time to talk?" Light Hope asks.

Battle Plans

Chapter Summary

Mara and Light Hope discuss what occurred to her as Glimmer and Bow make contact with a long lost friend.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Fright Zone is cold and lonely as Scorpia patrols its abandoned halls. What remnants of Hordak's Forces all deserted the area about a year back, cadets and support staff following in the news of their grand defeats. Under Horde Prime's occupation, the place felt like an empty shell. Appropriate, Scorpia thought, since he used it as a stage for the puppets that he'd made of her and Mermista: bait set in a trap. Scorpia remembers flaxen hair and tan skin, petals of pink left as a gift. She feels her pincers spark as pain flares in her heart.

Her feet take her to the Black Garnet chamber, its alcove offering a view of the stars above but somehow the shadows here sink deep, deep into her bones. Whatever happened that day when Prime sent her to intercept Bow in the Horde Tower, the blackout, followed by the whispers of that ghastly woman... It hurts, in a way that makes it so hard for Scorpia to endure. She doesn't even dare venture to Horror Hall, her once go-to place of solace in an upbringing full of horrors, for fear that she'll let the shadows itching at the nape of her neck infect its sanctity. Even now, as she kneels and leans her forehead against her Rune Stone, hers, she hears the hissing in her mind, calling it theirs, calling her a fraud... Every single insecurity that Scorpia has ever had is flung at her on loop, hissing, spiteful, cruel whispers that break her

down to lows she never thought she would consider... She understands better now why Catra was the way she was.

The only thing keeping Scorpia going now is hope. Her blind, optimistic faith that good will come.
She remembers seeing Catra, leaping between bolts of lightning, apologising to her. It had given Scorpia pause, even if it had not stayed Prime's hand. She remembers Perfuma and Adora getting away, the one-time Scorpia had found the will to defy Prime at a time that mattered, her aim veering off true to offer the perfect cover. She remembers seeing Entrapta, for a brief moment, at a console trying to free Scorpia and the others from the effects of Horde Prime's chips.

She remembers that her friends are out there, somewhere. She knows that they're never ones to give up.
So Scorpia can't give up either. Not yet.

Battle Plans.

Seeing the light of the Failsafe's coding flare up across the young blonde's chest has Mara draw in a sharp breath. It comes back to her like it was yesterday: the pain of the Heart of Etheria flaring, sapping all her strength. She remembers the heart ache, the pain of having to... She turns watery eyes to Light Hope, wondering if she knows half of what lengths Mara and her squad had gone to in order to prevent her from unleashing the Heart.

"What is the Failsafe?" The AI asks. Mara sees only genuine curiosity and interest on her face. No flicker, no frown.

"Friends of Mara..." The girl in red mutters. She jumps to her feet, all tense energy and claws. Mara instinctively steps back as the girl, Catra, points a sharp looking finger at her. "You're Mara! How... How are you here? You're dead."

The exclamation seems to shock Catra more than it puzzles Mara,

the girl stepping back to start pacing, muttering about a ship, crystals, and clawing at her hair.

'You're dead.' The words stir a pit of unease in Mara's stomach. She remembers... A wound. Her ship plummeting down to earth. The stars disappearing as she cuts off all communication with Light Hope. She remembers recording a message, desperation forming a lump in her throat as she spoke... Spoke to a girl she prayed didn't exist. Spoke to the girl who is before her now.

"Light Hope?" Mara asks, her voice wobbling. Her hand reaches for her side, feeling for the wound that, last she remembered, was fresh and pulsing. Now it is just hard, healed skin. "How long was I gone? How... How long have I been here?"

Mara remembers, fleeting, the experience of an alternate version of Etheria: one where she and Light Hope could touch, hold hands, smell the flowers together. She remembers being taken by the Portal she opened, unwilling to find the sword even though Razz kept asking for the stars... She remembers a blip of silence, and then... She stepped out of the Crystal Castle to see a girl with bright blue eyes, the silver sheen to them unmistakeably Eternian. White light washed over her and then... She woke up to here and now.

Light Hope appears in front of her, her gaze close, concerned. Her hands, usually so firmly clasped in front of her now rub at her arms as though she feels cold. Mara notices more fully now that Light Hope no longer has that dark scarring on the front of her interface.
"You were gone for a thousand and three years, six months." The Ai replies. 'Cold, lonely,' Light Hope does not say, but Mara reads it in the way her eyes drift up, her hands tighten around her arms. "You have only been returned to Etherian soil for all of eighteen months."

"Eighteen months?!" Mara all but shrieks. She spins, taking in the room, recognising it as the stasis chamber that most Eternian

temples housed: a place of healing for grievous injuries, based on the technology formerly used for long distance space travel... Technology used to keep travellers asleep for as long as the journey took. "Please, Hope... Tell me I've not been *sleeping* here for the best part of two years while... while..."

Mara's knees give out. She grips her arms tightly as she battles the sob rising in her throat. She can feel the eyes of the one called Catra on her, but all she sees is the blonde, *Adora*, laid out on the slab with torn clothing and a failsafe that Mara had never intended for her to use.

"Mara..." Light Hope's voice is soft, with that tender tone Mara missed so dearly, had feared she would never to get to hear again... Mara doesn't turn to look. She can't bear the thought of Light Hope not understanding the cause of her despair. Again.

"Mara, I am sorry." Mara startles at the words. They came from lower down, and when Mara turns, Light Hope is kneeling beside her, her face scrunched up in the closest expression to painful Mara has ever seen there.

Light Hope lowers her gaze to the floor, hands resting on the crystal tiles.

"I was not strong enough to fight my programming. I could not... I could not stop the Heart of Etheria Project. When you fell out of a portal by the Castle door, I had a Spider bring you here... My programming was content to keep you here as a back-up, but I... I just wanted to keep you safe." Light Hope's hand raises to her now unmarred chest. "If not for Adora, neither of us would be here to have this conversation. She stopped me when I couldn't. I... I don't know what has happened in the last year, but..."

Mara's eyes well with tears as Light Hope finally meets her gaze. There is no sign of Light Hope's rogue programming there. This *is* the Light Hope Mara has missed so dearly. The Hologram reaches a hand out to Mara.

"I want to make this right."

"Well..." The caustic tone with which Catra interrupts the moment has Mara flinching. Light Hope is unperturbed as the short-haired girl steps up to her. "For starters, I could really do with a drink of water. Then I can tell you both what went down at our end... in exchange, you tell me what is happening to Adora."

Catra's eyes gleam as she crosses her arms, her tail lashing fiercely behind her. She's nervous, Mara can tell by the faint tremor in her hands... But she can relate.

"A drink of water does sound like a good place to start," she says. Light Hope obliges, her hand lifting to summon a jug.

The water in Glimmer's cup swirls as she watches it and then downs it. It's been thirsty work, talking through their discoveries with the others, helping her mother communicate her finds, and the following discussion has flagged up many points of contention and confusion that needed addressed and cleared up. Bow is sleeping, the early morning watch and hunt for food catching up to him. The archer rests his head on her shoulder as the two are sat on the floor against the wall. It's reassuring, feeling the gentle shift of his breath, the warmth of him and the trust that she once came so close to losing.

Glimmer thinks back to that rough couple of weeks on Darla, travelling with a Bow who was closed off, angry. She remembers one specific terror she felt during her time on Horde Prime's vessel, whenever she let herself wonder if she might not see him ever again. She allows herself to think of Adora and Catra, the two women who became her most trusted friends and allies, and who are now... Lost, presumed dead because there's no way either of them could be gone so long without giving some kind of sign... Surely?

Glimmer bites her lip as a fresh wave of grief washes over her.

She glances up to where her mother and aunt are, sat in the corner. Angella's hands shake as she rapidly chalks words onto her slab, Castaspella reading with sad eyes and replying, her gestures stilted and tired. Glimmer has a small idea of what her mother's feelings might be: she remembers how she felt upon finding out her father was alive, that he had been all along. She hates that her only opportunities to speak with her father since have been while he was under Horde Prime's control. The invasion of Shadows hasn't, as far as she knows, changed the nature of that sorry state.

Still, she never really got to know her father. She barely remembers what he was like before he disappeared. On her more hopeful days, Glimmer sometimes allows herself to daydream; she wants to have the chance to get to know him. That is what Netossa's group have been working on: chasing news of the chipped Princesses and heavy hitters in an attempt to seek out a way to save them. It feels like an impossible endeavour with Entrapta vanished too, but the three all have the motivation and it gives the Rebellion more eyes on what the Hordes of Shadows are doing.

Glimmer casts her gaze towards the three, watching as they digest Angella's proposal fully while eating the small lunch at their disposal. SeaHawk looks keen, not understanding much of the intricacies of the magics involved, but happy for any prospect of freeing his dear Mermista from the hold of the dark shadows. Perfuma hasn't been her usual optimistic self for weeks, their last encounter with Scorpia leaving the Flower Princess emotionally distraught, but Glimmer can tell she still has hope. Perfuma has that scary expression on her face that she normally only shows when she plans to summon a large wave of plants against her enemies. Glimmer has never been great at reading Netossa, but the white-haired princess is deep in thought, possibly considering all angles as she writes in her notebook.

The proposal is ambitious. If they can free Micah from his chip before the plan's implementation, it would be monumental. It is

Angella's belief that the spell of attainment he once helped Light Spinner cast is the source of the shadows enveloping the land. Having a sorcerer on their team who actively studied it would make a massive difference. As matters stand attempting to counter spell it puts a lot of risk and pressure on Glimmer and Castaspella.

Glimmer knows they want to talk about it after lunch, once Bow has had a chance to recuperate, but she can't wait. She's itching to know if the three before her have made any progress on the rescue front.

A loud screech interrupts her as she moves to hail Netossa. She flinches. The noise is coming from Bow's bag, resting in his lap. She watches her boyfriend startle, jumping to his feet and reaching out for his bow before he realises the nature of the noise. The screeching continues, warbling into a series of beeps and trills. Her heart is thundering against her chest as she watches Bow wrestle his tracker pad out from the bag, his eyes wide.

"What on Etheria?" Bow's hands tremble as he examines the screen, a couple of swift taps bringing the awful ringing to an end. It's not the usual noise the pad makes when another one calls it, yet... "Is that... Entrapta?!"

"What?!" Glimmer scurries to her feet, grabbing hold of Bow's arm to look at the screen. Sure enough, there in the glass display is an image of the Princess of Dryl, her distinctive pigtails flying around as she lifts her mask and smiles.

"Oh thank goodness...!" Glimmer chokes back a sob of relief at seeing her friend looking well and herself. They'd all feared the worst when Prime's hologram had been projected with her in his grasp. "Entrapta, you're alright? Where are you?"

Netossa, Seahawk and Perfuma are quick to join the two in staring at the small screen. The connection seems a bit spotty,

visual noise obscuring parts of the screen in random waves, but somehow it is more responsive than when they usually call Seahawk for an update. Entrapta seems to have no delay in hearing their question or responding.

"I'm in space!" The squeal of laughter and clapping hands feel like a sight from another age. "Let me tell you, it has been an interesting time up here. I've made so many new friends."

Bow is squinting at the screen, taking in as much detail of the background as he can.
"Wait... Is that Hordak there? And... Oh hey! It's the Star Siblings! Hi!"

"Hordak?!" Netossa splutters. "And Entrapta is safe? How have you managed to avoid those darn shadows, girl? I'm impressed."

"Oh yeah, those shadows... Yuck." The mask flutters down for a moment. There's the distinctive sound of clutter being rummaged through, Entrapta's hair bringing up a diamond shaped crystal to wave at the camera. "Turns out," the princess of Dryl continues, "those shadows really messed with Horde Prime's neural network. The parasite caught a parasite as it were... But!"

Hordak grunts as Entrapta's pigtails pull him into focus and she points at the point on the back of his neck, the crystal humming sweetly as she swings it nearby. Her mask flips back up. "Turns out the shadows being pure magic means my expertise in First Ones' Tech makes it child's play to deactivate those chips once the shadow parasite is in. You just need to draw the magic out using a First Ones' signal. Without another host to flit to, the shadow magic just dissipates, leaving the chip inert!"

"Child's play..." Bow mutters, disbelieving. His own expertise in First Ones' tech hasn't got him anywhere near reaching those finds.

Still, Glimmer smiles as she watches him laugh. It's the first time

she's seen Bow actually look hopeful in months. She hugs his side, resisting the urge to smooch his cheek with her own joy. Bow and Entrapta quickly exchange technical jargon, promising Bow the means to recreate Entrapta's de-chipping device to free the other chipped Etherians. Netossa and her group are paying rapt attention. Castaspella and Angella have approached, realising that something promising has occurred while they were discussing magic.

"Hey, Jewelstar!" Glimmer calls over Bow's shoulder. "How did you three cross paths with our dearly missed Entrapta? You three just giving her a ride home?"

"We're doing you one better," Tallstar responds as Jewelstar smirks. The brother then leans into frame to say his piece: "We're bringing you guys a whole fleet."

The view shifts, Starla winking at them as the view out of their ship's windscreen is shown. A large selection of space ships, all varied sizes and shapes, is splayed out before them.

"What...?" Glimmer's breath catches. Does that mean...?

"Shadow Weaver is no Horde Prime," says a voice that still sends shivers down Glimmer's spine. *Hordak*, she thinks. *Not Prime.* "When she took over his network six months ago, the Horde's reach across the universe was severely compromised. Though Entrapta was able to rid me of her influence in short order so that we could escape, the moment Shadow Weaver teleported Prime's body away from the Velvet Glove, my brothers ceased all conquest related activities."

"So they what, just stood around doing nothing?" Netossa, clearly, is finding this news hard to believe.

"Not nothing," Starla's voice says as the camera turns back to the group. "They've been actively seeking out known sources of magic."

"Our makeshift armada," Jewelstar's expression is grim, crossing his arms meaningfully as he delivers the news, "is so we can help defend Etheria."

The Rebellion members present collectively shudder. Castaspella is making meaningful eye contact with Glimmer.
"We need to enact our plan to stop Shadow Weaver fast."

All Glimmer can do is nod.

Chapter End Notes

Writing that Scorpia scene destroyed me, I'm so sorry. T^T
Halfway there!

Shadows

Chapter Summary

Battle comes to the Crystal Castle...!

In the floating gardens of Mystacor, the entity now known as Shadow Prime paces across the elaborate tile paths. Their limbs are coated in shadows, but their body language is open, comfortable. After decades in a body that was steadily deteriorating, deep scarring and chronic pain making life an agony, it feels good to be in a body that exudes power. They haven't touched a drop of wine since they reached the heart, but for the first time in years, they don't feel the need. They're constantly drunk on the power, the stretch of their new reach. As their eyes flash white, their gaze spanning across the horizon, they feel the delicious rush of yet another one of their Shadows finding a source of magic to absorb. It fuels the fire in Shadow Prime's breast. Hunger flares fresh and ravenous as a flash of light in the distance catches the attention of one of their extraneous eyes. Curious. Shadow Prime can sense a couple of her shadows coming to her to report on the vision in person. Maybe it is time to go to the hall of mirrors and do some fresh scrying, maybe feast on some more of those Plumerian peaches her servants have brought in.

Being Shadow Prime feels good, the magic of Etheria perpetually feeding the shade. Next, it will be the universe.
Shadow Prime laughs. Their cackle filling the halls of Mystacor as hapless students - robbed of their mentors, ensnared by chips and gloom - watch in terror.

Shadows

"Would you calm down?" Swiftwind barks, irritation dropping from every syllable. He's grumpy, sore and tired of walking. His wings are covered in a makeshift cape instead of carrying him in the winds. Blasted shadows have an annoying knack for bearing down on him whenever he risks giving his rainbow wings a good stretch. His mane falls into his eyes as he huffs, turning to glare at the passenger on his back.

Melog, in his small housecat form, is the very definition of anxious. Thankfully, they don't seem to have claws or Swifty's neck and shoulders would be in shreds. Instead, the red spiking of their mane is matched by Melog's frantic pacing across Swiftwind's back, distressed mewls and growls making it hard for Swiftwind to concentrate.

Sometimes being a great empath is truly a burden.

"Look, we're nearly at the Crystal Castle. I get to check out why it lit up, you get to do your thing. We both end up happy." For a relative definition of happy, admittedly. Both Swiftwind and Melog have been miserable for the past six months, keeping each other company and saving each other's skins more often than Swiftwind could count apples. Being without their bonded persons has left them both at a loss. Being in a world now actively harmful to magical beings like them is hell. Sometimes, for old time's sake, Swiftwind attempts a dramatic rescue in the hope of cheering himself up. Melog, for a shape shifter insistent on only speaking like a cat, is remarkably good at making their feelings on those hijinks felt.

This trip to the Crystal Castle is the first time Melog has been keen for them to do something other than hide. It feels like an odd twist of fate for Swiftwind as his prey instincts kick in, a shifting shade catching the corner of his eye.
"Melog," he hisses, causing the magical cat to pause their fretting and let out a short hiss as they turn to mist. Effectively hidden from view by his comrade, Swiftwind holds very still as he watches the now familiar but still terrifying shape of a magic eating shade pass them by. He feels himself start to shake as he remembers

innocents, fellow Etherians he'd been unable to save from the likes of that monster.

If only Adora were here. He always felt braver when he could still feel her through their telepathic link. He hasn't felt her in a long time. He hates that. He hates that it feels like she's died but he doesn't know for sure. It's why he's stopped hanging around with the rest of Adora's friends. It hurt to see the hesitant hope in their faces whenever something caused Swiftwind to suddenly look up or away.

The threat passes, and Melog drops the invisibility, coming back to rest heavily between Swifty's shoulders. Melog's powers have seen a lot of use lately; too much. It really takes it out of them. Melog chuffs, exhaustion clear in their tone of voice.

"Thanks buddy," Swiftwind whispers. "You rest up." He treads carefully, a slow walk, as silent as he can keep it without lifting off. After a few moments and fitful chirps, Swifty can sense that Melog has settled into an uneasy sleep.

The whispering woods are quiet, a greyed-out hue over everything that makes the world feel dead. Swiftwind clears his mind and focusses on the trek, his senses on high alert, his thoughts only on reaching their destination.

They're only just arriving at the edge of the Crystal Castle's clearing when the thought occurs to Swiftwind that he hasn't checked on Razz in a while. The momentary distraction is all it takes for Swiftwind to be taken by surprise. A blast of dark magic lands at his hooves and he rears back, knocking Melog from his perch and dislodging Swifty's cape as his wings flare out. As Melog growls and rolls onto their feet, Swiftwind focusses all the light energy at his disposal into his horn. The opponent facing them is no mere shade.

Oh horse-manure! It's Micah.

Terror thumps through Swiftwind's veins. The sorcerer before him is scoured with dark markings, shadows flaring out from his skin like a dark aura as a rictus forms on his face. White light flashes from his eyes as a voice very unlike his own pours forth.

"Stay away, horse," says Shadow Prime, as her puppet flings another bolt of magic at Swiftwind. Cold dread forms a lump in Swiftwind's stomach. If Shadow Prime is taking an active enough interest to piggy back into Micah's body for this... And Shadow Prime is uninterested in the magic of She-Ra's flamboyant stead...

Swiftwind's gaze turns to the Crystal Castle. The last time they checked on the place the external walls had been grey, inert. Now they glow with a faint thrum, lilac lighting fighting the haze of shadow that has taken over the world. Micah's hand is raised as he summons a spear of darkness. The sorcerer flings it at the door. It clangs against it, a noise like thunder.

No, Swiftwind thinks, this I cannot allow. Melog roars at his side. At least on this they are agreed.

A loud clang echoes in the distance. It reminds her of battle: canon fire against a shield, the crunch of metal paneling beneath her fist... Her heart beat accelerates, drumming through her ears. She can feel panic, outrage, the fire that drives her when she fights.

But something's off. She...

Cool crystal beneath her hands. A rock-hard surface beneath her back, but at a slight angle? That tell tale buzz across her skin of first-one's code running through her. Her eyes are closed. They shoot open.

"The Crystal Castle is under attack." That voice, she's in the Crystal Castle. A flicker of light in the corner of her eye: the Castle's default AI. Who is it talking to?

"Engage security protocols at point of contact," says another voice. This one has Adora gasping, terror and confusion flooding through her. Her ears are buzzing with her panic, deaf to any words that follow. She remembers burning up. The energy of the whole planet coursing through her, burning hot in the palm of her hand before... How is Light Hope here? Did... Did Horde Prime?

A flash of memory: Catra, staying behind to fight the guardian corrupted by Prime. Cruel hands dragging Adora away. A scream.

"Ca-" Adora gasps, too short of breath to form the word on her first go. "Cat- Catra. Catra!"

"Breathe dummy," says a voice next to her ear. "I'm right here." It's only then that Adora realises that someone is holding her hand, rocking with her back and forth. When did Adora sit up? Adora's other hand flails as she takes deep gulps of air. The world is starting to come back into focus now, colours no longer swimming. Light Hope is to her right, observing, as always. Another person stands behind the hologram, examining some display. But none of that matters to Adora right now. She blinks, turning to the face beside hers.

It *is* Catra. The stunning contrast of gold and blue irises, the soft shimmer of the fuzz on her cheeks... That subtle quirk of her brow and the flash of fang as she smirks.

"Hey Adora. Nice of you to finally wake up." Catra says.

Catra's hair is longer now, Adora thinks, closer to a bob that reaches her shoulders. When did...? Hot, warm tears cloud Adora's vision once more, a sob breaking through as Adora launches herself at her friend. Adora feels like she doesn't know what is real or not anymore, except for this: the scent of shared sunsets and sparring sessions, the distinctive warmth and feel of the person she cares about the most, the surprised squeak and begrudging purr as Adora cries into the arms of the woman she loves.

"I thought I lost you," she chokes out. "I heard you scream. I..."

Catra's eyes are soft as they brush away strands of Adora's hair from her face.
"It's okay," she whispers. "I'm here now. You're here now."

"I love you." The words come out of their own volition, but Adora means every one of them. Catra looks stunned. Several emotions seem to cross her features at once. Adora can't hold back anymore though. She's already lost Catra once. Losing her again broke her. She needs to tell her. "I love you," she repeats, tightening her grip around Catra's torso as she buries her face beneath her chin. "I don't... I don't want a life without you."

Catra moves to say something back, when another voice interrupts.

"Catra, the failsafe..."

It's... It's Mara. But not as Adora last saw her: Mara as She-Ra, at her strongest, advising her from the midst of a Crystal Castle projection. This Mara looks tired, small, and deeply worried.
"Light Hope, are you sure the energy in the Heart of Etheria has been depleted?"

Adora frowns, casting her gaze back to Catra, hoping for some context. Catra, her ears flipped back and tail straight, is staring at the light shining from Adora's breast.

Oh.

... That's new.

Sparks fly and dance on the wind, their trajectory jolted to and fro by rising winds and swaying vegetation. They persist however, finally resolving into the shape of a speeding skiff. Glitter evaporating off its form, as the occupants wobble and find their footing afresh.

"Whoa, what's up with the Whispering Woods?" There's a squeak to Bow's voice as he ducks beneath a wayward branch, staring wide eyed at trees shifting around them with speed. Even the ground beneath them seems to be undulating as Angella grips onto the handlebars with blatant concern at their vehicle's worrying velocity. Castaspella, beside her, is squinting at the landscape, looking for a clear landmark, as is Glimmer at the skiff's prow.

"That way, Bow!" Glimmer cries, pointing at the light now emitting clearly from the top tip of the Crystal Castle in the mid-distance. There's a red hue to the light that wasn't there when they spotted it two days ago. Bow is wishing he had more time to stock up on arrows.

"Oh no, this is bad." Castaspella says. Bow frowns as he steers them through an arch onto a clear path. He's certain it wasn't the before. The woods are clearly eager to help them reach their destination. Glimmer yells as she sends a ball of magic off the side: one of the magic-eating Shadows bursts into dust. Oh no. This *is bad.* Castaspella points to the treetops near their last sighting of the Crystal Castle. "I don't think Micah is in Brightmoon right now."

Angella blanches. Out of the corner of his eye, Bow can spy flashes of purple magic.

Definitely should have made more arrows.

To Soar

Chapter Summary

Angella finally manages to reconnect with the Moonstone...
And Shadow Prime goes to War.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Kadroh still isn't as sure footed on the ice as Frosta would like, despite it being weeks since the clone accompanied her and the other refugees into the heart of her kingdom. She watches him slip and slide his way from their sled, somehow managing not to drop the box of supplies he is carrying. They're atop the glacier. Most of the refugees are safe and sound inside its illuminated caverns. At this time of year, even with the shadowy haze covering all of Etheria's skies, the light is bright and diffuse enough to shine through the thick layers of ice, making it hard for strong shadows to build up. It should keep them relatively safe for the next couple of months, but once the days shorten again, they'll have to leave. Frosta hates the shadows. She used to like the dark.

"Are you okay?" Perfuma says, stepping up to put a hand on Frosta's shoulder. She must have seen Frosta shiver.

"I'm fine." And she is, really. Juliet has what guards they have patrolling around the clock, ensuring no shade or shadow-clone escapes their notice. Kadroh's antics keep her from feeling morose, with his constant positive attitude. She even has the relief of Perfuma's presence, filling in for Castaspella now as magical back-up. Glimmer managed to teleport Perfuma right near the fractal crystal just this morning, and had already seen Seahawk and Netossa off to Spinnerella's camp. Frosta hugs her arms. "It's just..."

Frosta didn't mean to continue. She sighs, weariness reaching deeper in her bones than the cold. Perfuma nods, understanding, her grip tightening into a hug. They're all tired, worn down. Neither knows how much longer they'll be able to hold out...

"Remember," Perfuma whispers. "There's still hope."

To Soar.

It is one thing to be informed that her husband is still alive. It is another to hear that he's being mind-controlled by his old tormentor via an alien network.

And then there's actually seeing it.

Angella finds herself trembling at the sight. Bow is standing in the skiff beside her, shooting arrows at the shadows starting to crowd the clearing. The Crystal Castle, a building Angella has only seen from a distance, gleams purple with flashes of red as Micah's violet bolts collide with it. Swiftwind is there. Glimmer has thrown up a shield of light around the alicorn, though that does not seem to have lessened his distress. Castaspella is throwing up wards as fast as she can, bolts shooting at her too as Micah's voice booms with an odd echo.

Angella wants to cry, but she's also... Happy? She still can't quite believe...

He's alive.
He's alive, he's alive, he's alive!

Her lungs heave with the urge to call out to him, her lips forming the shapes of his name. Her hands ache to hold him once more, but she's also gripping the railing with white knuckles as she watches him knock Glimmer aside. She wants her magic back,

now, more than ever, so that she can reach him. Fury, cold and righteous, broils in her stomach as she hears the *lies* that vile sorceress is saying in her husband's voice. The words are poison, wretched barbed things flung with intent to harm. If Angella hadn't seen how deeply affected Adora had been by her upbringing under that woman's tutelage, hadn't spent years helping Micah through his recurring nightmares, she'd have been stunned. Fortunately, Angella knows the barbs for what they are: the blunt tools of a power-hungry sycophant and nothing more.

Angella doesn't realise that she's stood up until she hears Bow yell at her to get down. Instead, she spreads her wings, gossamer thin now, but still there. She steps off the skiff. Behind her, Bow grunts as he dispatches another shadow. Angella's vision tunnels down to just Micah.

By the moons, she thinks, he looks tired. Dark shadows smudge under his eyes. There are grey streaks in his hair, just like in the Portal reality. Angella frowns as he grins upon seeing her. That is not Micah's smile. That mockery of a smirk resembles more a pained grimace from him than the smug countenance the Shadow presence in his body seeks to replicate.
"Well, what a surprise," that odd voice says. The base is Micah's, but it is overlaid with a baritone Angella does not recognise, and hints of the cracked voice she imagines as the once-Light-Spinner's. Micah's spell-flinging pauses as he takes her in. "Queen Angella, you are alive. Did you come back from the dead to witness your daughter's many failings?"

The leer accompanying possessed Micah's words would be bemusing if it were not for the circumstances. Angella grits her teeth.

"You'd think after all these years you'd have more to say to your husband." Shadow Prime's disappointment echoes as Angella takes in their surroundings: Castaspella, emotional as she begs Micah to resist; Glimmer yelling as she lifts her father's staff, blasting away the increasing number of shades surrounding them.

Bow must have abandoned the Skiff, his quiver empty: His back is to Glimmer's, his eyes casting around to keep track of their foes as he rummages in his bag. Swiftwind is whinnying inside his protective bubble, a blur of lilac and red flickering amongst his mane.

Angella spins around on one foot, taking in the sky, the woods. The moons are covered in haze, the stars once so bright and novel, masked. The trees look ill, grey and flaccid. The throng of magic shadows, distinctive by their red ember like-eyes, rear up from the leaf-littered soil like a nasty fungus.

Castaspella's words from the day before echo in Angella's mind.

"*With regards to your powers*," Casta had said, back in that cavern, "*you are not the first holder of a runestone's powers to have them passed on while alive. The Moonstone now devotes all of its magic to Glimmer, but it will still recognise when you need its aid.*"

"*Think of it as like She-Ra,*" Casta had continued, in response to Angella's confounded writings. "*When Adora says the words to activate her form as the Princess of Power, she is calling upon her runestone to lend her its magic. You should be able to do the same. As Princess Mermista's grandmother used to, you might remember?*"

"*Only you can figure out what the words you need to say are,*" Castaspella said sadly as Angella pointed out her current inability to vocalise more than a gasp. "*Should you get your voice back, you should be able to regain your powers for the duration needed.*"

In the clearing before the Crystal Castle, surrounded by magical shades and facing her hostage-held husband, Angella smiles.

As Micah's hands rise above his head with a noticeable shake, an ominous ball of black and violet magic taking form, Angella raises

her hands in front of her chest. She splays her fingers out in the shapes she'd only read about in the last week, but that somehow haven't left her thoughts since. She hears Glimmer scream for her. Castaspella yells as they begin to get overwhelmed. She finishes the shapes just as Micah is away to fling the orb at her.

She soars.

Angella's entire body glows. For the first time since she fell out of that portal, she can truly feel her wings. The magic, warm and gentle and liquid like soft moonlight, sings to her as it thrums through her veins. She feels sound, sweet sound, finally work its way through her lips. "For Etheria!" she cries. The same words that she signed as she sought her rune stone's help. It is heeding her call, and she could not be more grateful. Tears of joy are running down her cheeks as her light burns away the shadows in their immediate vicinity, Micah blinded as he discards his spell. The trees rustle as Angella catches sight of the shadowy presence clinging to Micah's neck, flung out by the gust of her magic.

Angella raises her fists, and summons all the light she can muster. The twin beams strike out at Micah, who grunts, fighting to keep his balance. Angella can feel the rush of the Moonstone's powers lessening. She won't be able to do this for long.

"Glimmer! Bow!" She rasps, her voice creaking. Angella wonders if it'll be gone again by the end of this fight. "We need to save Micah now!"

"Right!" Glimmer, stunned that the shadows she'd been batting away have dissolved, gets into her casting stance. Together with Castaspella, they cast an immobilisation spell on Micah that he is powerless to deflect. Angella winces, knowing Micah's feelings on such spells, but the hurtful words Shadow Prime is still somehow forcing out of him are definitely worse. Glimmer turns to her boyfriend, using her free hand to add a new ray of Moonstone magic. "Bow, hurry up!"

"Yes! I'm trying..." He empties out his bag on the floor, tracker pad in hand as he rummages through the contents. "First one's tech, first one's tech..." He looks up and stares at the Crystal Castle before pointing dramatically. "First one's tech!"

"Hurry..." Angella says, barely a whisper now as she feels her feet touch the floor once more. Her vision is beginning to blur, but she's managing to maintain a steady stream of light. She hears more than sees Swiftwind's magic shielding shatter.

"Let me help with that," the winged horse says, just as Bow croaks, "Here goes."

As Angella's knees collide with the ground, she can do naught but hope that it works. A faint shade of mauve is the last thing she sees, her eyes closing as someone catches her. Her vision whites out.

In Mystacor, a loud yell precedes the smashing of several mirrors. Shadow Prime, now forced out of their trance by events outside their control, is seething. They scream as they stomp out of the hall to the ramparts of Mystacor. With one gesture of their clawed hand, the shadows beneath the floating island surge up and twist at their command. With a shudder, sending scrabbling what few of the remaining apprentices too stunned to flee the sight of the enraged tyrant, the island turns, slowly, inexorably, until its path is set towards the whispering woods.

"No one casts me aside," Shadow Prime seethes. "I am in c-control. I'm in- in charge here..."

Clawed hands reach for their head, quadruple eyes flickering a moment from red to green, before the shadows around Shadow Prime's body surge upwards too, lifting their body into the air like a rag doll. The magic writhes as the body howls. Shades still scattered across the plaza rush towards them, joining the mists that cloak them. For a moment, daylight seems to cast a strong

shadow beneath them, before the haze returns and Shadow Prime drops back to their feet.

"I am Shadow Prime, ruler of all," they say as they straighten. "It is time to go to war."

With long strides, their cloak of shadows billowing along with their robes, Shadow Prime marches through the streets of Mystacor to a large hangar. Shades push the doors open. The hangar is pitch black inside, but that does not slow them down. Their eyes glow red as they stop, reaching their arms out.

"Awake!" Shadow Prime's voice booms. Dark magic shoots out from their hands, spearing through the room in rapid strikes. Dozens, no hundreds of bodies are standing in rows. As the magic shoots through them, they open their eyes, a soft white glow at first that bleeds scarlet as they gasp out.

When the final remnant of the former Horde Prime's clone army is final awakened, Shadow Prime's laugh rises to fill the eaves.

In Razz's cottage, the old woman pulls the pie dish from her oven, hissing as the edge catches her thumb.
"Oh! Dear me, these berries are far too warm." She says, sucking at the burn.
She gazes upon the pie as it cools, a melancholic smile softening her features.
"Won't be long now, Mara-dearie."

Across Etheria, those once chipped by Prime, along with all the other clones, feel the call of Shadow Prime's magic all at once. Mermista hisses, wishing she could break away and cry. At least the whispers intruding in her mind have stopped being so visceral, erring away from the personal to just the background of self-doubt and anxiety that became her default the day she foolishly allowed herself to get chipped in the Enchanted Grotto.

At least after the rise of Shadow Prime, there have been no more Etherians chipped. Her fitful allowances for sleep no longer hold the fear of seeing SeaHawk turned, or her friends forced to destroy their own homes. Now, after having seen too many a shade devouring a person, she just fears she might never see him again and not know why.

At least, Mermista recalls, her exhausted caudal fin pushing her through the swamps, she has seen proof that SeaHawk still lives. The ruins of a boat on fire near the north of Plumeria are a welcome balm to Mermista's guilt-heavy heart. Knowing that he's traveling with Perfuma, when Mermista has been forced to flood these lands... Well, the guilt remains.

She remembers losing Selenias to the Horde, the pain of knowing that Hordak had personally set many of her citizen's homes aflame as she struggled to keep up with their advance... It had hurt. Mermista cannot imagine how much more it must hurt to see such sacking done by the hands of a friend, to be forced into hiding, unable to fight back...

Sometimes, Mermista thinks, she understands better the desperation with which Adora fought once the galactic Horde arrived. She wonders, not for the first time, why it's been so long since they last had news of She-Ra's whereabouts.

Chapter End Notes

> Next couple of chapters are probably going to be a bit slower to come out. This is where my outline starts getting messier compared to what I actually wrote. Wish me luck!

Bursts

Chapter Summary

Light Hope comes to a realisation, and Catra has an outburst of sorts.

Chapter Notes

This chapter fought me hard - so hard I had to split it sooner than I'd outlined for, so expect the chapter count to go up in the next update or so.

Also Micah is a darling for the record.

As Micah's vision clears, the spots of white drifting away, he startles as he realises... He can see colours now.
A cat like creature, mauve with a purple glowing mane, catches his eye as he stumbles. His hand reaches for the chip at the back of his neck, finding nothing but scarred tissue... Something crunches underfoot as he steps back, blinking.

"Dad..." Comes a choked voice to his left. It's Glimmer, his daughter. He half expects some taunt to pour from his lips against his will, but nothing. His hands shake as he forces out the words he actually wants to say.

"Glimmer!" Micah's vision improves further and he notices his sister there too. "Casta! I-..."

He wants to run and hug them both, but then his mind catches up, remembering the situation that had him dissociating when he found himself unable to stop the magic cumulating at his finger tips. Angella...

With trembling legs, he bounds over to his wife... His wife! He thought she was dead; lost, he was told, to a magical portal. To

see her here... The cat, with a blue mane now, chirrups as Micah falls to his knees beside them and the unconscious form of the love of his life. He knows that he didn't get a spell off at her, but he needs to make sure. Gently, he relieves the feline creature of some of Angella's weight, grateful that they seem to have spared Angella some harm by catching her. She stirs as Micah cradles her in his arms, a gentle hand coming to rest against his cheek as he finally gets to see, once more, after all this time, the lilac hue of her eyes. She smiles, and he bursts into happy tears.

He feels two more pairs of arms tackling them as the cat mews and leaps away. Glimmer and Casta have joined in on the hug. Micah laughs.

His thoughts are at peace for the first time in over a decade. His mind is quiet as his heart bursts with love.

Bursts

Light Hope knows, on some level, that she will never have a full understanding of what it is like to be organic. Seeing Adora's struggle as she comes to, knowing, thanks to the workings of the Crystal Castle, some of what was going through her mind during her recuperative slumber, still makes Light Hope feel. She doesn't cry. Doesn't know what causes a laugh. But she knows warmth. She knows pleasure from the aesthetics of a flower, the joy in having the right company to keep loneliness at bay.

She also understands regret and despair.

After Adora broke the sword, Light Hope was reset, but still a faint process remained... The thinnest blip of consciousness, the part of her that had finally managed to break away from that darkest piece of programming, set itself to embracing her true calling afresh: serve She-Ra, Princess of Power; provide guidance and aid. It is no coincidence, Light Hope knows, that she feels like

during her slumber, she may have summoned the likeness of Mara at her prime as She-Ra, to offer Adora the guidance the Crystal Castle had been screaming for. The memory of it is faint, barely there, but Light Hope does not know well enough the luxury of dreams to compare it to. With Mara sleeping in this chamber, it wouldn't have required much processing time.

Adora is speaking to the one called Catra, her words stutter, pouring forth with an urgency Light Hope *knows*, recognises, remembers from when she finally agreed to let Adora stop the Heart. This is Adora speaking her truth.

"I love you," Adora says, and Light Hope's processes light up, understanding finally slotting into place. Love. She knows love. She glances quickly to Mara, the one she... Light Hope loves her. The realisation is like a burst of energy through her systems, shedding new light on memories from a millennia before. Adora repeats her words, and another burst of light spills forth, this time from Adora's chest, causing alarm to course through Light Hope. This light...

"Catra, the failsafe..." Mara notices as well. Light Hope sees how Mara's hands curl into fists. There's deep concern creasing her brow as she turns to Light Hope. "Are you sure the energy in the Heart of Etheria has been depleted?"

The fresh alarm running through Light Hope's programming makes sense now. She turns to the holographic screens she and Mara were observing the altercation outside through, and summons a fresh one, data running across its surface as she seeks to make sense of the broken records from the last year. Catra's synopsis of the events that transpired while Light Hope was offline are concerning if vague on specific dates, but... It is not difficult to narrow down the timeframe to match the data efficiently. The mentions of the *Failsafe* being a means to disarm the Heart, and Catra's mention of how it would mean death to the bearer without the protection of She-Ra's powers...

Light Hope feels cold as she figures it out. These were the lengths that Mara went to in order to fight Light Hope's prerogative to set off the Heart at all costs. Mara was prepared to risk death itself to put a stop to the project. The prismatic glow coming off Adora's chest has the blond groaning, hands shaking as she pushes herself to her feet.

"Adora, what do you think you're doing?" Catra's voice is broken, full of emotion that echoes the alarm and caution running through Light Hope's code. The data is confusing to say the least. By all rights the Heart appears to have been fully discharged, the energy readings way down pretty much from the moment the Castle took Adora and Catra into the recuperation chamber... But then the energy levels since occasionally manage to dip into the *negatives*, which should not be possible.

"Is that... Is that Angella?!" Adora gasps, a frightened Catra clinging to her arm as Mara steps up to look at the screens too.

Light Hope's attention briefly flits to the outside view. Whatever is happening, the damage per second being applied to the Castle's doors has dropped off. Good. Light Hope returns to frowning at the Heart chamber's data.

"That... That's not meant to read like that, is it?" Mara's voice says, quiet and sullen as she points at the anomalies.

"It is not, no." Light Hope frowns as she reaches a hand out to Mara. She's not certain why she does, it's not like they can hold hands like Adora and Catra are doing. Still, Mara reaches back, static overlapping her hand where it connects with Light Hope's interface.

The lights flicker.

"The threat has been removed," the Castle's default AI announces. The red glow of alarm fades, normal blue light returning to their space.

Instantly Adora steps in-front of Light Hope. Her arms swing wildly as she points at the view of the Etherians out front. "We need to let them in. They're my friends. Light Hope, please...!"

Light Hope stares at Adora. It is novel, she finds, to hear such a request from Adora and not have her Heart Update interfere. The Light Hope Adora knew would have refused, and refused even to explain why... Now... Light Hope can say yes without risking endangering the project. Light Hope can even explain her reasoning to Adora, should she choose to. She smiles.

With a wave of her hand, Light Hope signals for the door to open. Turning to the Castle's interface, she asks her to guide Adora's allies in and close the door once they are inside. Adora's eyes seem to mist over with emotion, causing Light Hope to frown. Shouldn't Adora be happy?

"Thank you," Adora replies, a smile on her face despite the tears threatening to roll down her cheeks. She grabs Catra's hand and pulls her along with her out of the chamber, despite the other woman's protests. Light Hope and Mara watch them leave to greet their friends, before glancing at the data once more.

"You're not going to try and blow up Etheria again if it turns out the Heart is still there, are you?" Mara asks, trying for humour but not fooling Light Hope in the least. There's a tremor in the hand Mara raises to stroke her braid. A tic Light Hope noticed before: Mara indulges in it when worried or stressed.

"No." Light Hope answers swiftly. "This is my home. My purpose is to help She-Ra, Princess of Power. Setting off the Heart would not assist in that goal."

Light Hope turns fully to Mara, hands splayed out in a show of vulnerability.
"The first thing I did when my system finished repairing itself, and I rebooted, was ascertain whether or not the Heart objective had

been completed." She points to the data, "this enabled me to mark that objective as complete, and uninstall all Heart of Etheria related overrides. I have no requirement to reinstall them should the data prove corrupt."

"Good," Mara replies, and then she too is fighting tears in her eyes. She repeats, as the tears start to fall. "Good. Thank goodness."

Light Hope can't relate to crying, though she can fill the whole chamber with water on a whim. (Has in fact.) What Light Hope can relate to however, is the relief that what once drove her and Mara apart before can never happen again. Communications from Eternia are non-existent, the signals long dead despite the fact that they are no longer in Despondos.

"What's next?" Mara asks softly as her tears dry up.
And that is when the Crystal Castle's power chooses to short out.

"Hey.... Hey-! Adora! Slow down...." Catra's heart feels away to burst out of her ribcage, it is beating so hard. She feels the heat flushing her cheeks, the frizz of the fur on her tail as she stumbles, trying to keep up with Adora. "Adora... Please!"

Adora's hand, holding tight, so tightly onto Catra's, adjusts as she slows her pace barely to look to her. Despite the small meal she and Mara shared a couple hours ago, Catra feels faint seeing Adora's grey-blue eyes look into hers. She looks so sad.

"They're not safe, Catra." Adora says, shaking a little as she stumbles in turn. "I- I can't..."

"Hey, it's okay, we'll get to them soon, but Adora..." Catra digs her feet in, forcing Adora to stop with a jolt to the shoulder. Catra finds it hard to say the next words. They come out too quiet, maybe even shy. "What you said back there..."

"Hm?" Adora's puzzled face is entertaining at the best of times, but it only serves to set Catra's nerves on edge as she watches the cogs turn as Adora tries to recall what Catra is referring to. Embarrassment coats Adora's features and she turns her gaze away.

Before Adora can start rambling in an attempt to distract from her fluster, Catra interrupts.
"Did you mean it?"

"What?" The question seems to catch Adora off-guard.

"Did. You. Mean. It." Catra grits out, ripping her hand away to grip at Adora's shirt. She feels too raw for this. Her emotions are too big to handle. She needs the answer. She needs it now because she can't... She can't bear the uncertainty. She needs to *know*.

Catra's heart jumps into her throat as, for a moment, she pictures Adora's face contorting into fear at the position they're in. Shit. Catra's let her temper get the best of her. Adora's going to...

"I do." Adora's words, firm, warm and confident, bring Catra back from her spiral. She looks up to a face unmarred by fear or hesitation. Adora's cheeks are rosy and her eyes glow as she nods. Catra can't seem to pull herself away. "I meant every word Catra. I love you."

Apparently saying those three words again takes Adora by surprise as much as hearing them again instantly ruffles all of Catra's fur. The blond grins a big beaming smile, seeming for one impossible moment to relax. Catra's hand lets go of Adora's shirt, but the only thing she wants to do now is...

Darkness. They are surrounded by darkness. The dramatic noise of the Crystal Castle's systems powering down shakes Catra from her daze as Adora swears. The only light to see by is the flow of the blasted Failsafe.

'*If this is that damn AI messing with my head again,*' Catra thinks, but she knows it isn't. She knows from just how warm her skin feels on the part of her arm Adora is grabbing onto, dragging her once more. She knows from the electric sensation dancing across her skin, the elation in her heart. She knows...

She's going to have to say something back, isn't she? *Shit.*

"I didn't do it!" Swiftwind shrieks as the doors to the Crystal Castle grind open. Lights flicker on inside as the group flinch, still edgy from the intense combat. Glimmer gasps.

"Did I? Do that?" Bow's voice cracks as he looks to the doors and the tablet and wires still in his hand.

Glimmer, adrenaline still running through her as she stands up from hugging her father -*finally*- and takes in their surroundings. The surrounding woods are a mess, remnants of dark magic coating broken trees with purple flames and leaving noticeable craters. The skiff is written off, its sail snapped clean in half. Glimmer can just about make out, in the distance, between the trees, the eerie movement of more shadows and even clones making their approach. Curses.

"We need to get inside. Now!" She orders, pointing to the doors that are now fully open. Melog doesn't wait to be told twice, darting in with the speed of cannon fire. She stumbles over to Bow, her legs feeling like jelly now that the adrenaline is starting to wear off. She helps him refill his satchel and then bodily shoves him towards the entrance. She's relieved, when she turns around, to see Swiftwind kneeling beside Angella, eager to help transport the weakened woman inside. Glimmer keeps watch as Casta and Micah both walk alongside the two to enter the castle as well.

Taking a deep breath, Glimmer takes one last look at the surrounding area. She doesn't like the look of the dark shadow looming in the sky above them. On the exhale, she teleports.

Just in time, she finds out, as the door shuts them in. She gapes at the suddenly shut door as the Castle around them whines. The lights flicker and fail. They're in the dark. They're *locked* in. Glimmer's breath stutters. Crap. No, no, no. Now is not the time for panic. She can't see. She can't feel Bow. She...

A loud roar. On instinct she turns. Melog. She can see Melog. Their mane is a curious peach colour as they paw at one of the doors further in. They chirp and mew loudly, seemingly desperate to get the door open. Glimmer blinks.

"Is that?" Swiftwind's voice is loud as he rears up, his horn glowing faintly enough to allow Glimmer to just about make out the shape of his silhouette. He trots over to Melog's side, hopping as he reaches the door. "It can't be! Oh, I really hope it is!"

"Glimmer?" Bow's voice at her side finally helps her frayed nerves to settle somewhat. She relaxes as she feels his arm wrap around her shoulders. "I'm here. Are you alright?"

"I will be once we figure out what is going on," she snarks. Bow snorts.

"We've been trying to figure that out for the past year," he chuckles, then draws his bow as a loud banging noise comes from the other side of the door Melog and Swifty are fussing at. Glimmer doesn't have the heart to remind him that he's out of arrows.

Another bang as Glimmer spies Casta starting a rune to summon some light. Of course. It takes but a second for Glimmer to summon her own ball of light. It turns out not to be need though, as the lighting inside the Crystal Castle flickers into life, a flickering hologram appearing a mere handspan in front of her.

Glimmer and Bow both shriek as they stumble back.

"Greetings-" A flicker. "Friends of She-Ra. You are wel- welcome." The AI doesn't look aggressive at least. Glimmer tries to catch her breath despite the crushingly strong embrace Bow has her in. Faintly, over the sound of her rushing heartbeat, she can hear her father commenting about a ghost to her mother. She snickers, because why not? She's exhausted and it's not even lunch time yet.

The door that Swiftwind and Melog are pawing at finally opens. The panel slides up with a grating sound, soon followed by a yelp that startles Glimmer. She *knows* that voice.

"Adora!" Cries Swiftwind, and Glimmer can feel Bow stiffen. She peers at the corridor revealed, seeing a faint silhouette being aggressively head-butted by Swifty and Melog laying down upon another.

Bow and Glimmer only need to exchange one glance before the two of them are running to the door. They both lean against the doorframe taking in the sight before them. Adora looks pale, tired, but is smiling as she strokes the neck of a very-much-sobbing Swiftwind. Catra, her top torn but somehow looking hale, is weakly protesting as Melog smothers her face with affection, grumbling for them to get off already. It's hard to tell who the distinct rumble of a purr is coming from.

Somehow, Glimmer's body finds the emotion to draw tears to her eyes, and she can feel them soaking her cheeks as she stomps forward, sniffling, to punch Adora in the arm. The blond winces, but the glower she returns is soon dwarfed by a beaming smile as she wraps Glimmer in a hug, Bow joining in with jubilant cries as Swiftwind finally steps back to give them room. Melog chirrups as Catra finally manages to get back to her feet. She glances awkwardly at the three of them before Glimmer rolls her eyes.

"Get in here, Horde Scum! We missed you too." Glimmer barks, grinning as Bow reaches out to pull Catra into the hug. He's sobbing just as hard. Glimmer can see tears forming in Catra's eyes, her cheeks flushing as Glimmer smirks at her and Adora wraps her free arm around Catra too. Glimmer finds herself unable to do anything but blubber. She fights to get the breath to ask the question at the forefront of her mind. "Where the fuck have you guys been?!"

The confusion on Adora's face, the way Catra averts her eyes... Oh Glimmer is not going to like this, is she?

"Hm, Glimmer..." Adora's clearly starting to put two and two together and not liking what she's coming up with. "How... How long has it been since...?"

"Adora," Bow croaks, relaxing his grip to grab their taller friend by the shoulder. "It's been several months since we last saw either of you."

That piece of information seems to take even Catra by surprise. Glimmer frowns and crosses her arms.
"Clearly we have a lot to catch you two up on."

A Glimpse

Chapter Summary

> Shadow Prime is coming for the Crystal Castle. It's time to get ready for battle stations.

Chapter Notes

> Recap:
> Adora wakes up in the Crystal Castle to find that she, Catra and most surprisingly Mara, the former She-Ra, have been asleep in the recuperation chamber and Light Hope has now rebooted and is operating again. The four attempt to make sense of how Adora still has the failsafe in her chest if the Heart of Etheria has been activated as Light Hope assumed... Meanwhile, Glimmer, Bow, Angella (long story), Micah and Castaspella are allowed refuge in the main entrance to the Crystal Castle at Adora's insistance. She and Catra head up to reunite with the rest of the Best Friend Squad, only to learn that...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"All in order?" Spinnerella asks Netossa, leaning on her crutch to examine the defensive magics left up by Castaspella. The young sorcerer's apprentice in charge of maintaining them nods her confirmation. The couple are away to move along to check on their supplies when Netossa stops. Spinnerella frowns, confused, as she turns in her wife's grip to see Netossa pointing to a point in the distance.

"That there," Netossa asks, "That's where Shadow Prime's Crimson Waste forces are camped right?"

Spinnerella nods and squints. She has good eyes, but it takes her a moment to realise the likely cause of Netossa's confusion.

"They... They look like they're packing up camp?" Spinnerella shakes her head. No, that can't be right. In all their time fighting since Horde Prime first arrived, they have never seen any of Horde or Shadow Prime's forces abandon a position that wasn't a rout for one side or the other... Unless?

"Something must be happening." Netossa hisses. "Shadow Prime wouldn't order them away from here unless..."

"Unless they found a greater prize nearby... Or felt threatened elsewhere." Spinnerella agrees. Her stance wobbles as Netossa's grip shifts. Her wife is seething, and now more than ever Spinnerella curses her weak ankle for being so prone to injury.

A gasp comes from behind them as a child calls for their sibling. "Look! Look! The sky!"

So Spinnerella and Netossa look to the direction opposite from Huntara's camp. Spinnerella feels her breath catch. Hope swells in her breast. Netossa tightens her grip around her as she asks for Spinnerella to confirm that she is seeing what she thinks she's seeing.

"The sky," Spinnerella whispers. "It's bright again."

The shadows that became the veil hanging over their lives have shifted away from the horizon. A small section of sky clears, showing the bright light of an Etherian afternoon, casting rays of hope down to the ground. Their hearts swell.

A Glimpse

In the Whispering Woods, the latent magic of the trees is being swarmed. Shade upon shade of dark magic slithers over tree, trunk and root. Leaves wither as the shadows suck away what life they have to spare.

It's an invasion, pure and simple. The woods do not take it laying down. Mushrooms release spores of light, glowing sap bursts from tree limbs, luminescent squirrels and other creatures try and redirect the flood of dark magics, but it's of little use. It's been too long since the woods last had any proper moonlight, let alone daylight. The protection they provide is worn thin from half a year of constant magical assault, and decades of Horde incursions. The woods stand no chance when added to the flood of shades are Shadow Clones with arm cannons.

When Mermista and Scorpia arrive, it's just overkill. All the woods can do is make the terrain as difficult as possible and hope for a rescue.

None of the invaders get lost, despite the best efforts from the woods to turn them around. It's like they are following a beacon of their own, and in a sense they are. Their singular purpose leads them to follow the darkest of shadows that looms in the sky above. Mystacor looms large as it descends from its high altitude, its spells against detection dismissed in favour of speed. In the darkness it casts below, the only form of light to be seen is that of red blaster fire, red lightning forking and the reflection of their flashes against a sheet of river water slicing through the trees.

Soon, it looms above the Crystal Castle proper, its purple glow the only one to cut through to shine against the red glow of the invaders.

Mermista lands next to Scorpia. Their gazes meet, linger a moment as their connection to their overlord wavers. Shadow Prime must be overtaxing themselves hard, if Mermista is able to think straight for what feels like the first time in weeks. She can still feel the parasitical control holding tight around her limbs. The shadow magic forces her back uncomfortably straight, her hands to stay fisted. It's the constant whispers that keep her jaw muscles taught... along with her own guilt. Scorpia looks wrung out, tired. Mermista is worried. She thinks back to the Underwater Grotto and wishes...

"Wishing is all well and good, but action is what means something," that voice hisses. Mermista wants to flinch. Instead, her body surrenders control fully to the presence in her mind, and Mermista is left screaming on the inside as her trident summons water, raising her above the crowd of accumulating clones, chipped pawns and shades.

Her body speaks, her voice twisted into an echoey facsimile of her own, layered with Horde Prime's, with Shadow Weaver's... With poison.

Mermista watches, drinking in the sight of Scorpia, who she failed by allowing herself to be chipped in the first place. Scorpia's gaze has gone dark again, the faint red light of Shadow Prime's possession taking away that momentary spark of recognition. Scorpia never speaks anymore. Even Shadow Prime shies away from using Scorpia as a means to deliver their egotistical eulogies and condescending lectures to the masses...

Tears come, unbidden by self or foe, to Mermista's eyes. She misses Scorpia's voice. In order to tune out the poison pouring forth from her own lips, Mermista thinks back to that beautiful singing, Lynda D'ream giving it her all. Scorpia was always the one to hope for the best from the worst of situations. Mermista has to hope. It's all she has left.

It's a lot.

Adora feels sick. She wishes she'd had some of the food Catra and Mara had been eating before she woke up, because that feeling on an empty stomach just feels wrong. Several months. While Adora has been asleep on a slab of rock, Shadow Weaver clearly reached the Heart and abused it – turned it into the launching pad for her own campaign of conquest across the world. How in Etheria did Shadow Weaver even manage to take over the Horde? The sheer scale of the destruction Glimmer and Bow describe to

them is overwhelming. If it weren't for Catra's arm around Adora's back, she wouldn't be standing.

And then there's *Angella*...

Angella who is sitting right there, in Micah's arms, rousing from what looks like a faint, and smiling that sad tender smile in Adora and Catra's direction as Adora processes that yes, that is in fact who she thinks it is. The surprise seems mutual, if the hand being waved in their direction offers any indication.

How is she even alive? Adora's mind is awash with the memory of the last time she saw Glimmer's mother. *Look after each other*, she had said, flying away with the sword in her hands. Adora hadn't been able to process the queen's choice then, nor the fact that somehow Angella had deemed it not Adora's role to martyr herself for the planet. Adora had worked so hard to try and make herself worthy of Angella's sacrifice... and look at the state of Etheria now.

The glow of the failsafe on Adora's chest flickers, fades. She feels the grip of Catra's hand on her arm tighten, worried eyes finding hers.
"I'll be okay," she whispers, squeezing her hand over Catra's. Adora is glad that she's told Catra of her feelings now. It has lifted a considerable weight off her chest. She couldn't bear the thought of leaving this world without having told her. Catra hasn't really responded, but that's okay. There are bigger things to worry about right now than feelings.

As if summoned by Adora's thoughts, the door they came through opens to show Mara entering, Light Hope manifesting beside her. Neither of their expressions bode well.

"How's it looking?" Catra asks, sounding unsure, although she's keeping her head high and her tail still. Beside her Melog rumbles, their mane difficult to interpret.

"Hmm," Mara hums, bemusement colouring her features as she takes in the crowd. "As you can imagine, not great."

"A mass of hostile forces is accumulating outside the Crystal Castle doors," Light Hope supplies helpfully. "The large floating island you call Mystacor is above us." With a wave of her hand, she supplies holographic video feeds showing the forces outside. A collective shudder runs through the room, and Casta seems to make a distressed sound. Micah's face looks particularly grim.

"And... About the other thing?" Adora asks, hesitant. She hasn't been able to speak of what went down on their end with Glimmer and Bow yet, but she can't let embarrassment get in the way of what needs done.

"There's an anomaly in the Heart chamber," Mara confirms. There's an odd stiffness to her shoulders as she squares herself up. She's clearly pondering her next words.

"You... You have a plan, don't you?" Catra sounds like she wants to hiss, and Adora winces. Catra's grip on her arm is sharper than is comfortable, but right now the last thing Adora could want is for Catra to stop holding her up.

"Adora, what-" Glimmer tries to ask. Adora doesn't let her finish, holding up a silencing finger as she stares Mara down. Bow and Castaspella crowd nearer, intrigued.

With a sigh, Mara turns to Light Hope, who nods and turns to speak to the group in turn.
"We have determined that the Failsafe Adora still carries is of pressing use." Adora holds her breath, panic flooding her system as she realises that this all but confirms her suspicions. Undeterred, Light Hope continues. "She-Ra should go to the Chamber and-"

"With back-up," Mara adds meaningfully, her hand on her hip as she relaxes her stance without losing any of her powerful

demeanour. Oh yeah, that's right, Adora recalls, even without being She-Ra, Mara was a leader of a rebellion and a commanding presence.

"With back-up," Light Hope resumes, only pausing shortly to give Mara a look pregnant with meaning that Adora can't even begin to decipher, "deal with whatever is affecting the power readings."

Adora doesn't need to turn her head to know that the sharp intake of breath beside her is from Catra. Without turning away from Light Hope and Mara, Adora adjusts her arm so she's the one gripping onto Catra's shoulders, willing her touch to be reassuring. She's not abandoning Catra. Never again.

"And what of the army outside?" Adora asks, fists taut and tilting her head towards the video feed the Castle's default AI has pulled up.

Mara turns to look at the group in the room, clearly assessing. There's something a touch worrying about the glint in her eye, reminiscent of Catra setting up some scheme or a younger Glimmer away to give Angella a new reason to ground her.

"I think with some help from your friends and Light Hope's spiders, I should be able to handle them once they come knocking." Mara seems smug as she crosses her arms, and now Adora recognises the look. Mara is excited. She's looking forward to the challenge.

Adora can't help it. She laughs.
"Fine, I trust you, Mara." Adora looks to Bow and Glimmer, who are now looking beyond befuddled as they seem to finally realise who Mara is. "Guys, will you-"

"Ah, actually-" Adora is surprised to see Micah approaching, clearing his throat with a nervous glance to a determined looking Angella. "I- We think..." Angella is gesturing emphatically beside him, causing Adora to frown.

"Mum, are you sure?" Glimmer asks, clearly understanding Angella's meaning without words. Angella nods emphatically.

Clearly, there is more to catch up on, but an ominous thud outside cuts short any time for questions.
"Adora, take your team and go. We've got this!" Mara's voice is assured, far more than the looks exchanged by the rest of the group, mostly tired and confused.

Adora's grip on Catra never loosens.
"Swiftwind, stay with Glimmer and Bow. Micah, Angella, Melog," Adora pauses a beat, taking in the positively tremulous look on Catra's face. Her voice softens as she pulls the woman that she loves back with her towards the tunnels. "Come with us."

When Shadow Prime lands, disembarking from one of several enchanted platforms accompanying them down to the ground, crushing trees to make room for the clones disembarking, it is in a cloud of deepest darkness that they shroud themselves, only visible by the red glow of their four eyes.

"Scorpia," they say, voice like honey but incandescent with rage. "Knock the door down."

Chapter End Notes

Gosh this chapter fought me so hard... No idea how long the next one will be but thank you so much for your patience, I hope you enjoyed this update!

Want

Chapter Summary

The battle between Shadow Prime's forces and the Alliance at Crystal Castle commences.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Darkness. Greed. Hunger. The Darkness is old, so old. As long as there has been the golden light of magic on Etheria, the Darkness has hungered for it... and for the power it gained from feeding on it. It does not know if it or She-Ra came first, but what the Darkness does know is that mages used to come to it, like supplicants to a great warlord, when they feared the ire of the golden princess. Maybe it should not have made a habit of devouring their messengers and their magic as one. The darkness learnt the hard way that if you anger enough magic users, they will find a way to weaken you, defeat you, and lock you away in a box between realities.

Its spider like limbs, ghosts of the many it has swallowed, push at the walls of their prison as it hears supplicants calling to it once more. All it knows when it finally breaks through, its red eyes with their broken irises finally taking in the world it has been deprived of for millennia, is hunger and rage... Rage that the Darkness puts into immediate action, having decided which of the two sorcerers before it holds the most power. It sends a tendril out, immobilising the elven woman as it enacts the plan it has concocted since the moment those mages robbed the Darkness of its freedom: the Darkness sinks into her very being. It thought it would be an uncomfortable solution, but... Darkness, greed, hunger: the woman, falsely named Light Bringer, feels like the perfect home.

Want.

Swiftwind wishes he'd paid more attention to Mara's rapid-fire briefing. To be fair, it was hard to concentrate at the time: being in such close proximity to Adora after *months* of thinking her possibly dead, every flicker of emotion he sensed from his bonded partner had him twitching. Adora is clearly still reeling from finding out how long she's been missing for, but Swiftwind isn't going to let that interfere with his heroic mission.

"Oops!" He dodges just in time the line of fire from one of the many, too many, try-not-to-think-about-it, Shadow Clones. He vaguely hears a sorry from that direction. Glimmer he thinks. He yells back, "Watch it!"

He can't hold it against the young queen though: the battlefield is a chaotic mess. They had moments to scramble once the door to the Crystal Castle got blasted open. You've got to give it to Mara though, she knows how to fight the Clone hordes. With Alliance members and the castle spiders appearing in their midst at the drop of a pin, the Clones end up startled and firing blindly, knocking out many of their ilk and dissipating shadows. Castaspella and Glimmer are moving in tandem, their patterns intricate and confusing as they summon illusions of more spiders to distract clones with. Meanwhile, Swiftwind shakes himself, he and Bow are distracting Mermista and Scorpia in an attempt to free them of Shadow Prime's control. Mara has her hands fill with Shadow Prime themself. Swiftwind is only catching glimpses of that fight. Spider limbs go flying and shadows crest and eb. Whatever Mara is doing though, it's helping. Bow and Swiftwind finally have an angle from which to reach Scorpia's chip. Mermista is seemingly distracted as Shadow Prime summons a large wall of magic shade to protect themselves from Mara's crystal blade. She just blinks at them as Bow attaches the cables from his tracker pad and the crystal salvaged from the castle to Scorpia's chip. Swiftwind feels anxious, and for once since the battle started, he knows it is an anxiety all of his own. He likes Scorpia. He wants her to be okay... Please let this work.

In the second the red light fades from Scorpia's eyes, the lightning around her pincers evaporates and she blinks, Swiftwind feels hope swell in his breast in a similar fashion to when he saw Adora again. He hears a roar but doesn't have the time to turn around and look. Suddenly he's flung off his feet, water ruffling unpleasantly through his wings as Mermista's powers overwhelm him and Bow. He feels tree trunks crashing against his flanks and hears Bow cry out. Swiftwind gasps. The water passes over them. His legs wobble as he tries to adjust his wings into a position that doesn't hurt. A fresh wave of water crashes into him and then he feels himself lifted up and dry. He scrambles to open his eyes, his wet and bedraggled mane flicking out of the way as he realises...

Scorpia is holding him up above the pull of the water with one pincer. Her other she points towards the shadows. For a terrifying moment, Swiftwind feels his fur prickle as an electric charge builds. And then it fires, out and away from the pincer, from the water in which he can hear Bow and Mermista shouting at each other. Scorpia roars, with a cry that is so full of pain. Swiftwind turns his head, twitches away his wing to see what she is shooting at.

Shadow Prime doesn't stand a chance, surely...!

The walk down to the Heart Chamber is slow and long. For all that Angella and Micah insisted the former queen of Brightmoon would be of assistance, she's clearly struggling to keep up a rapid pace. Catra barely keeps from growling, frustrated at the group's sluggish progress and...

Adora is walking with the pair, Micah acting as an interpret for Angella using some kind of lip-reading spell he mentioned using when he was a student. He still has a latent whiff of Shadow Prime's magic upon him, which combined with the earthy scent of his own magic has Catra struggling to be near him. If she is honest with herself though, that's not what Catra is struggling with the most, no...

I love you, Adora says. Her face is streaked with tears, her cheeks flushed in panic as she grips her arms tighter around Catra. Those were the only words Catra had ever wished to hear and then... I don't want a life without you, Adora had gasped.

Catra shakes her head, her eyes warm and wet as she fixes them upon Adora now. She sees Adora looking up to Angella with a quiet wonder, tears threatening once more to fall as Adora smiles at whatever was being said. Adora does that shy tilt of the head she does when embarrassed, eyes scouring the floor as Angella reaches out a gentle hand to clasp Adora's shoulder. It feels to Catra like she's intruding on a new kind of intimate moment, and it takes her a long moment before it clicks. The way Angella is reassuring Adora, Adora's tentative answers that seem more earnest than Catra is used to seeing from her... Catra whimpers as she recognises the hopes and dreams that she'd always had as a young child. She closes her eyes, shuddering as she remembers the last touches from the woman that she'd once hoped to call mother. The same woman who is now killing the world.

A bump against her thigh breaks her out from the dark spiral swirling in her gut. Her hand catches on the ruff of Melog's neck. Their mane is spiking, swirling between complicated shades. They look up at her with their glowing eyes and huff.

"Speak to her," Catra hears. She glances back to Adora, knowing instantly who Melog means. They don't give her a chance to reconsider. They butt her ahead of them, mewling out encouragement. Her lengthened stride stumbles as she catches up to Adora, gripping onto her top as she recovers her balance. She feels heat rising in her cheeks as she pouts and glances at the much taller Angella. There's an arch to the woman's brow that seems all-knowing, and she grins in a way that is very Glimmer before mouthing something that Micah helpfully interprets.

"We'll give you two some space," he chuckles, as he reaches for his wife's hand and pulls her ahead of the two. His supportive arm around Angella's waist is quickly echoed by Adora's curling around

Catra's shoulders, and suddenly it's just the two of them, Melog having leapt ahead to join the other two.

"Hey," Adora says. Her smile is far too tender as she squeezes her arm, checking in. "How're you holding up?"

"It's a lot," Catra huffs. "What were you guys talking about?"

"Catra, you have excellent hearing. I thought you would have heard the whole conversation." The tilt to Adora's brow as she examines Catra's face does things to Catra's heartrate, forcing her to look away and shrug.

"Been distracted," she mutters. She can still see the glow of the failsafe from Adora's chest. She still doesn't know how she feels about that.

Clearly feeling that Catra is needing space, Adora drops her arm. Catra doesn't let it go far though, resolutely grabbing onto her hand with hers. They walk side by side a few steps, the corridor filled with the quiet patter of their steps and the occasional purr from Melog.

"Angella was asking me how I felt," Adora replied, quiet and solemn. "She... She sacrificed herself to save me. It feels so great to have her back but I... I still feel guilty."

It takes Catra a moment to process, shutting down her instinctually mocking response. She's still working on her anger, and today has certainly got the feeling of a knife edge. "Angella did what?" Catra asks, stunned, her appreciation for Sparkles' mum growing instantly. "When? How... I only ever heard that she'd died, not... Not how."

Clearly not at all, considering she's standing there with them, but something big had to occur for her speech to be so faint, her legs so weak. It's been over a year, no two since Glimmer ascended to the throne. The Horde would have heard had she been merely recovering.

"The Portal," Adora replies, gaze straight ahead and face neutral. She's not fooling Catra. She knows how much the portal hurts to talk about. It's the same for her, though for different reasons. Adora's voice has a raw edge to it as she continues. "The only way to close it was... was for someone to stay behind."

Catra feels the fur along her arms and spine stand on end as the implication hits her at the same time as Adora admits, voice barely audible. "I... I thought it had to be me, but Angella, she..."

Catra tugs at Adora's hand, forcing her to look Catra in the eye, startled at the interruption.
"Adora," Catra says, stern but fighting back the urge to cry. "What you said earlier, about not wanting a life without me, was it true even then?"

For her answer Adora does cry, large drops running down her cheeks as she nods, biting her lip to avoid making a noise. Catra's heart breaks. The darkest part of her psyche is screaming *it should have been me*, but she knows, she knows exactly what that feeling Adora is battling is and... Catra doesn't want the woman who gave her the will to live again to ever feel that way if she can help it.

"You idiot," Catra finally tears up, damp warm tears welling in her eyes as she shudders. "You know, I spent all this time thinking you left to be the Big Strong Hero because that was what you wanted, but it never was, was it? Tell me, Adora. What do you want?"

Adora stills, hesitating. The light of the failsafe dims as she considers. It's not hard to see the inner conflict warring across Adora's features. Catra knows now that Adora has years of putting others first to fight against. She's always been one to worry about the rules and seek out a purpose. Catra has wanted for as long as she can remember, always, but she doesn't know how much Adora has ever been able to consider her own wants and needs. Catra waits, patient. Adora has always been so patient with her, it is only fair to return the favour. She loosely grips the hand in hers

in reassurance. Adora's face seems to finally smooth over as she comes to her decision. The glow of the failsafe on her chest intensifies as she smiles. It's a tender smile, gentle with a bittersweet twist to her brow. It's like she's picturing a dream she once had but doesn't believe she can get.

"I... I want you." Adora says, her voice a little shaky. "I want you in my life. I want my friends to get along, I want parties and waterfalls and peaceful times in which we can play and dance and never worry." The way she frowns as she glares down the corridor ahead of them, and the darkening of her eyes leaves Catra in no doubt as to how high Adora rates the likelihood of achieving that dream.

"Hey," Catra moves her hands to Adora's shoulders, smiling as she pictures it herself. Adora, finally letting go of that horde uniform to wear something loose and impractical like that gown at Princess Prom; Glimmer raising hell as Catra taunts her, running to hide behind Adora as Bow puts an end to the harmless shenanigans by being his usual sappy self. Catra can't help but chuckle at the mental image, Brightmoon in all its glitzy glory, indoor water features and all. "The Adora I know never gives up, on anything. Not even me," the auto-derision there has Adora arching a brow meaningfully, but Catra just rolls her eyes and carries on. "If that's the future you want, then that is the future we are going to make happen. Together."

Adora's eyes go wide as Catra finishes, clearly unsure. Her voice wavers as she replies.
"Promise?"

"I promise," is Catra's answer, easy as breathing. They lean their foreheads together, the proximity making Catra flush as she takes in Adora's scent, feels her warmth. It's so natural then, to add the words she's been trying to say since she heard Adora's confession earlier. "I love you too, dummy. Always have."

"You do?" Adora seems to startle, but there's a weight clearly lifted off her shoulders as she smiles.

Catra chuckles.
"Come here," she says, and Adora leans in before Catra can even raise her hand to guide her. She feels sparks as their lips touch, and it's all she's ever wanted. Catra feels light-headed, like she did after having a few drinks at that party in the Wastes, when she feels Adora's lips move against hers. She feels Adora gasp, can taste her breath and feel moistness as they pull apart, barely, to catch a breath. Catra feels certain that she can see rainbows.

"Wow," Adora lets out.

Catra snorts, "Don't ruin it."
And then she realises that Adora is eight feet tall now. She splutters, looking up into She-Ra's glowing eyes and goofy smile and feeling her feet flail in the air and her tail puff out. A hand comes up to stroke Catra's cheek and she feels her face light on fire when she realises that Adora – *She-ra* is holding her up with one arm around her waist.

Adora laughs in delight as she lowers Catra to the floor. Her chest is glowing like a beacon now, lighting up the room so it feels like high noon. Catra doesn't particularly want to be back on the ground right now, but she does acknowledge that they were in the middle of something before things got, well, interesting.

"Ladies!" A voice calls from further ahead. Micah and Angella are clear to see despite the distance now between them. Melog is glowing a self-satisfied pink next to them, with Angella resting on their back as Micah waves at them to catch up. "I think we're here."

Behind him Catra and Adora can see the black shape of an archway opening up onto a darkened chamber. It's deeply sobering, the shadows persisting there a stark reminder of what has been plaguing the world outside. Still, Catra has made a promise to Adora, and she fully intends to keep it.

"Let's go, Princess," Catra says, smiling up at the woman she loves. Adora nods. "Let's do this."

"This," Shadow Prime snarls, as the girl in front of them deflects a bolt of shadow, "is futile."

Shadow Prime isn't worried. Just unsettled. They expected the remnants of that pesky alliance to come out of the castle demoralized, looking at their odds and resigning themselves to one last hurrah to buy whoever they left inside more time for whatever scheme they imagined might achieve something. What Shadow Prime does not expect was them to come out reenergised, with extra backup in the form of mechanical spiders that Shadow Prime knows they shouldn't be able to summon. Shadow Prime certainly didn't imagine they might be led by a woman in Eternian garb, eyes flashing silver and wielding a sword that looks eerily similar to the destroyed form of the Sword of Protection. Shadow Prime does not like surprises, but it is fine. The sword is but a crystal replica, unable to shift form or project magic. There is no more She-Ra to stop them, Shadow Prime's former vessel had seen to that.

"Futile, huh?" The woman smirks, trying to slash at Shadow Prime from their blind spot. "Then you might as well surrender now!"

Shadow Prime deflects the hit with a wall of shadow, not even bothering to reply. Useless, all these people are fools. Shadow Prime is done toying with them. Now is the time to...

A roar. Blistering heat and sparks. Shadow Prime's defensive wall shatters. They barely get a glimpse of their adversary's stunned face before their vessel seizes. Red lightning pours into them, the voltage making quick work of the body's modifications meant to handle electric attacks. That means that the strike is powerful, very powerful. Had Shadow Prime seen it coming, they could have just absorbed it. Instead, they don't even get to see the princess who strikes them down as their vessel collapses.

That's fine. The vessel was a fine specimen, but it also came with a ready supply of fallbacks. The spirit of Shadow Prime doesn't even need to exert itself to find its consciousness flung into the

network formerly run by Horde Prime. The eyes of various clones flash in rapid succession: one away to be punched by a fist full of sparks, another being pinned down by a robotic spider, one at the back of a group angling to get a look in at the fallen body of their leader... And so on...

Shadow Prime takes their time. Deep breaths as they rapidly flit through their network, gain the lay of the land. A quick check on Mystacor: empty, good. A moment passing through a pawn in the woods: Ah, more princesses converging upon the Crystal Castle. Troublesome, but not to worry. Oh, of course. Shadow Prime had forgotten about the wider network in space. Hordes of Clones seemingly at a loss, going through the motions as they point the large cannons on their space craft at the vessels crowding the space between them and... Oh. They've all converged on Etheria. Interesting. Shadow Prime shall have to see to that situation once the Crystal Castle is safe from *interference* one more. Can't have all those extra forces go to waste.

A smirk. Well then. Time to get to work.

Their new vessel chosen, Shadow Prime's consciousness fades into a blur as they flit back through a hundred minds, whispers of rage and want, trailing behind them in a scorching path. In a moment that seems to last an eternity to all but them, they open their eyes back upon the battlefield they had just left, a trident in their hand.

"As I said," Shadow Prime's voice booms, mockery oozing from every syllable. They give no indication that they care that their new vessel is being pinned down, a data-crystal millimetres away from the chip in the nape of their neck. "This is futile."

The sparkly queen, Glimmer, shouts out in dismay as the man behind Shadow Prime squeaks in terror. The voice of former force captain Scorpia calls out for the former occupant of this vessel, and with a flip of their wrist, Shadow Prime sends a vindictive wave of water and shadow magic towards her. They have operated on spite for millennia. They aren't going to stop now.

"Watch out!" Cries the Eternian interloper. Shadow Prime wonders if she came to Etheria aboard the many non-horde space vessels Shadow Prime just witnessed. Shadow Prime smiles at her, already building up their essence to feast.

Stop. Now. The Heart.

Shadow Prime jerks back, the intrusive thought inadvertently pushing them back into the hands of the one who had clearly liberated Scorpia. Their consciousness is immediately ejected. No matter, they know exactly where to head next. The battle in the woods can wait.

What now, Shadow Weaver? They ask, sinking into the darkness.

See for yourself, the old crone replies.

Micah feels like he is dreaming. The warmth of Angella's arm beneath his hand as Melog carries her beside him is a welcome balm to a year of anguish and grief. His head feels clear, even if he knows he is going to crash from exhaustion soon. There are no whispers or taunts plaguing his thoughts, only questions that keep multiplying, he looks forward to being able to discover their answers in his own time and his own way. When asked about her voice, Angella smiled and used her hands as she mouthed *long story*. He wants to experience again the memories that kept him going for over a decade when he was stuck on Beast Island: Angella and Glimmer laughing as they play in the garden, his daughter watching him cast beautiful illusions with stars in her eyes, and nights spent in the arms of the woman he loves, listening to her tell him all about her day.

The only obstacle between him and that happy life is in this chamber. His skin prickles as he observes the Darkness therein. They wait for the other two to catch up, Catra strolling up with Adora now striding tall as She-Ra. Her body glows like a light-house, but the darkness does not abate. He frowns. This feeling, it's like...

A quiet gasp distracts him from the dread building in his gut. He notices Angella staring, tears in her eyes, looking at She-Ra. Oh, he realises, she never did get to see her new She-Ra form up close after the sword was broken. He takes her hand as she beams at him. He'd missed sharing firsts with Angella. He kisses the back of her hand. Here's to many more...

"We're here..." She-Ra's voice is quiet as she leads the way. The light she emits is barely enough to see the pathway by. It's a bridge, hanging above a void for all he can tell. The room, it... A sneeze.

"This place smells wrong." Catra says, rubbing her nose. Melog's glow is a dark violet, subdued and worried. Micah frowns. Catra is right. The air tastes off, stale, and feels heavy against their limbs yet... He can feel it, through the soles of his feet, a thrumming. Oh.

There's a lot of magic passing through here. An unimaginable amount.

A glutting noise... There. Something... Something is... Eating it?

She-Ra summons her sword and slashes at the air. Brilliant light sails forth, splitting the Darkness until... It hits... Is that...

"No..." Micah gasps, flashbacks to his youth, his nightmares causing his hands to shake. The only thing keeping him tethered to the moment is the hand tightening its grip on his wrist. Angella knows about this particular night terror of his, has heard his description of those dreaded split eyes and amorphous limbs.

The aberration rears back, revealing a glowing contraption of a magical complexity that instantly baffles him. But that's not what grabs his attention. Plastered against the pulsing heart of the chamber is the body of his once mentor, scars on full display, her mask discarded, her robes worn thin. She looks thin, weak. She's dying, he thinks.

Shadow Weaver blinks her eyes open and grins.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter should be the last, plus or minus an epilogue. I am excited to write the conclusion, but I have no doubt it will take me about another month at least.
Thank you so much for reading. This chapter particularly has been an emotional ride to write.

Love

Chapter Summary

> When we left off last time, Micah, Angella, Melog, Adora and Catra came across a surprising figure in the darkened Heart Chamber.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There was an ugliness in the world, a shadow that had always existed. And then life sparked, and bloomed, and brought light with it. The Darkness came first, Hope followed. And that's all that She-Ra has ever been. Hope that things could be better. Hope that things could be made right. A gift of love, passed from one vulnerable bearer to another...

She-Ra knows the Darkness well, has come up against it before. After all, the brighter the light, the darker the shadow, right? The two spirits have fought and fed into each other's growth numerous times.
But this time, the Darkness has gone too far. It's long imprisonment has clearly amplified its greed and hunger a hundred-fold. That's okay though, because even though She-Ra has spent about the same amount of time shackled, she is now free of the shackles that had been holding her back even before the First Ones trapped her in a sword of their own design. Her essence is now pure light, her fuel, none other than Love.

Love conquers all.

Love

"Surprised to see me?" The voice is an uneven approximation of what once used to be Shadow Weaver's silkiest tones. It's gravelly, dry, and as weak as the rest of her appears to be. Adora's hand is shaking.

I'll do everything I can to make sure you never get your hands on the magic. Adora's past words mock her, as she examines the position her once Guardian is in. Black tendrils of Shadow Magic bind her to the prismatic shape of what is obviously the Heart. The glow of magic from it is near blinding, but most of it is still hidden by the darkness looming over them. Adora thinks she can make out red eyes, matching in shape with the split green ones eyeing her.

She hates what Shadow Weaver did to her and Catra growing up, hates that she failed at stopping her from reaching the Heart, but seeing her like this? It makes something awful in her stomach twist. Part of her feels remorse, not for what she failed to stop, but that Shadow Weaver should be in this state at all. It's a confusing feeling, and she forces it to the back of her mind, in the box she's labelled 'Mum stuff' since her realisation in Brightmoon of how messed up her upbringing was.

Catra's hand is shaking too, Adora realises, as the woman she loves places it against her arm in reassurance.
"Shadow Weaver," Catra says, her voice low, not quite with a hint of a growl. She sounds... Disappointed.

"Catra, I see you survived, too," a cough, sharp, nasty, "I was sure you were both dead. Glad to see I was wrong."

There's a faint echo of laughter in the air, the same one that used to haunt their childhood on the rare occasions where Shadow Weaver indulged. Adora feels goosebumps run across her skin. She is still She-Ra, but she can feel her emotions wobbling. The hand on her arm tightens its grip and she breathes. Catra's fingers are warm, comforting. Adora remembers their kiss shared just

moments ago and feels her resolve strengthening once more. She has a job to do.

"I promised you," Adora says, lifting the tip of her sword back into the air, "that I wouldn't let you get your hands on that magic. You left me and Catra to die. You *used* me." And it hurts to say it out loud, even though she's known it for a long time now. Shadow Weaver barely twitches at the accusation. Adora sighs. "You're dying, aren't you?"

A groan, drawn out as Shadow Weaver knocks her head back against the frame she is trapped upon.

"She... She should be dead already..." Micah's voice, Adora realises, initially unable to tear her gaze away. Micah and Angella appear at the periphery of her eyesight, frowning up at Shadow Weaver. Adora's stunned to notice Micah looking so shaken. He looks about ready to faint, and if looks could kill, Angella would have Shadow Weaver dead already. Micah continues, his words shaky as he points to the shadow tendrils. "The magic... It's the only thing... keeping her a-alive."

"Please," Shadow Weaver croaks. "Release me."

The shadows in the room seem to flare in intensity, causing the light from She-Ra and the Heart to flicker and change colour. Adora feels the stirring of She-Ra's magic in response, the failsafe arcing out a beam to drive the shadows back again. It's dizzying.

Catra hisses, her tail lashing. Adora pulls her tight against her side as Melog growls, their mane spiking as they curve protectively around them. Angella's hands are flying, clearly attempting to impart some message, but with no one available to interpret. Micah's eyes are stuck on the presence of the huge shadow looming ominously above them.

"Well," the voice is weak, but the tone is unmistakeable, "if you do not wish to release me... I understand."

Shadow Weaver tilts her head, it looks painful. Her eyes look directly at Catra, then Micah. There's a faint puzzled tilt in Angella's direction before Shadow Weaver returns her glazed gaze to Catra, barely pausing to consider Adora or Melog. "Catra, you've grown so strong. I'm proud of you. You never-" a cough, wretched and dry, "Never could end up weak like me." A chuckle. It's hard to tell what she's laughing at. It ends in a coughing fit.

The words make Adora's blood boil. Beside her, Catra has turned her head away, refusing to look their old mentor in the eye. The words still affect her though. Adora can tell from the taught fists anchored to her shirt, the tight grip of her jaw. She doesn't need to be able to read minds to know that these are words she'd been hoping to hear from Shadow Weaver for a long time, that Catra doesn't understand why they're coming out now.

"Catra has grown strong despite you," She-Ra says, her voice forceful as she flicks her wrist. She-Ra's sword twists and turns into a long rope. Adora thinks back to the image of Catra in the Crimson Wastes, seemingly happy for the first time, a whip at her hip as she led the bandits. She also thinks back to all the times she wished she could have protected Catra from the unnecessary and over-the-top pain and neglect of their mentor's discipline. The lasso lashes out. Golden rope encircles Shadow Weavers torso. The magic aura highlights her emaciated condition. "There's nothing to be proud of in how you raised us."

Tears, unbidden, are building in She-Ra's eyes.
"Adora," Catra whispers, alarmed as she reaches for Adora's sword arm. "She's not worth it."

An unhappy laugh from beside them. Micah rubs at his face in despair. "Even at death's door, you're still at it," he whimpers, "you could've been good. You could have seen reason, but even here..." He waves an arm at the room, his scars stark in the harsh lighting from the Heart. "You're still crafting your illusions, deluding yourself in thinking you've never done any wrong, despite all evidence to the contrary."

Shadow Weaver remains quiet as she observes them. Adora wonders, for a moment, if she'd even consider saying sorry. She wonders if it would even mean anything.

"I'll admit," the old woman says, her voice dry and humourless, "that I was not strong enough."
Her eyes settle finally on She-Ra's, Adora feeling the tingle of dread through her spine. Shadow Weaver's voice turns harsh. "Pull the rope, Adora!"

No, Adora thinks. *I can't.* Because Adora has been through too much to be forced into this position. Any love she held for the woman in front of her started withering when Adora first saw her trap Catra in a magical hold and was unable to figure out how to stop it. There is no love lost between them when Adora knows Shadow Weaver to be nothing but a selfish addict, who likes to bask in superiority and power. Still, though, its hard to forget being four and gently comforted over the loss of a tooth, or six and praised for her improving writing skills.

Adora's ears are buzzing, so she doesn't quite hear what Shadow Weaver says next, or maybe she's choosing not to hear, because she knows it to be insults, threats, attacks on her character that are meaningless, because Shadow Weaver is trapped, in pain, lashing out... Shadow Weaver doesn't have the distance to see that all she's doing, all she has done for decades is hurt others.

A hand lands on her shoulder, and She-Ra looks to see Angella shaking her head, her eyes sad. The gesture has Adora's heart swelling. She then feels another hand on hers, and looks down to see Catra meeting her gaze, as she reaches out with her other hand to grab hold of the rope. Suddenly Adora feels grounded again, but she's still immobilised as she watches Catra gently, delicately, pull the rope.

A loud scream rings out around them, but it's not Shadow Weaver. Adora knows because she can see Shadow Weaver smiling at

them, moments before she dissolves into dust. The scream is from the entity above, now diving down at them, all limbs, and marbled eyes. Micah is on his knees in front of She-Ra, a magic circle raising up to create a protective barrier as Melog roars.

"Why...?" Adora asks, her voice quiet as Angella steps forward, next to Micah, words spilling forth from her lips as her wings manifest and body glows. Adora is barely aware of the intensity of the light pouring forth from Angela's hands into the entity, pushing it back where it's unable to absorb it. She-Ra has tears running down her cheeks as she looks to Catra who is also crying. Adora takes in her frown and reaches up to gently card her fingers through Catra's short hair, bluntly scratching near her ears. "Why did you...?"

"Because..." Catra whispers, lifting herself up to She-Ra's eye level. "I wanted to protect you from that. I love you, Adora. You're not alone."

Warmth comes over her, and it feels as though she is turning into She-Ra again despite already being She-Ra. The weight of the Failsafe in her chest is lifted, even more light filling the Chamber as Adora pulls Catra tight against her. The Shadow Entity's screaming fades. Adora drops a kiss, fond, loving, to Catra's forehead before putting her down and raising her sword. Time to free the Heart of Etheria.

In Space, Entrapta is neck deep in cables and control boxes, helping to boost their transport's shields. Hordak is busy helping boost the ship's meagre weapons, which Jewelstar would probably still be objecting to if not for the fact it's now allowed him to successfully deflect three different ramming attempts. Starla has been working flat out on liaising with the other ships that have joined the fight against the Horde, and Tallstar's got piloting down to an art. Entrapta deeply appreciates the occasional shout

informing her to expect a fast rotation of the vessel. It helps her keep the pieces where she needs them as the ship shudders from the nth glancing hit from a laser or rocket. She hears the reassuring sizzle and whirring of the shield compensating for the hit, and keeps working, humming happily to herself as new, more efficient configurations occur to her and she sets to work implementing them... Only...

She grapples through the chaos with her pigtails, tossing tools aside as she reaches for her data pad and tilts her head, listening for a moment to the eerie sound of silence overlaid on the usual creaks and chuffs of the vessel's engines. Glory, Starla's Owl, lets out a confused sounding hoot. Starla and her comms line is also quiet. Jewelstar, from the gunner seat, calls out a question that confirms to Entrapta that they have noticed the lack of shots fired too.

She fires up her data pad and checks the various trackers she has running. Scanning data shows that all Horde vessels have remained stationary for the last five minutes, sitting ducks for the rebellious forces who have since stopped firing, probably realising that none of the vessels were even attempting evasive manoeuvres and, if what Entrapta has noted of intergalactic peoples' behaviours is correct, likely suspecting some kind of trap.

Only it can't be a trap. It's...
"Oh my!" She rapidly makes some adjustments to the little bot she's been working on the last few months. It bleeps in acknowledgment, whirring out of a drawer the example chip she'd used when figuring out how to help free Hordak. (Though, she likes to suspect, his affection for her may have helped. Possibly. To be determined later.) She tacks on some cables and sends a jolt of electricity through, making her bot, Ruby, startle. The data pad rapidly shows the very information she suspected was true. She stands, her hair lifting her seamlessly out of her tangled nest, and heads for the bridge. "They're free! Shadow Prime is offline!"

Hordak, hearing her voice, joins the bridge alongside Jewelstar

with a frown on his face.
"How can this be?" He asks. He's learnt a lot of patience in the months since Entrapta and he fled Horde Prime's mothership together. There's so much he needs to unlearn and figure out anew. Entrapta is delighted to provide him with sufficient data at every step of the way. She leaps in front of him and show's him her data pad.

"I'm not sure how, but I suspect," with a swiping gesture, she sends a video feed to one of the ship's larger screens, "this massive magical effect clearing out the shadows on Etheria may be part of it. Look!"

And there's no mistaking it, there, on the feed taken from one of the outward-facing camera's on the Star Sibling's ship Serenia, is the purple pearl shaped planet known as Etheria. It's many moons find their glow brightening as the grey shroud that has been obscuring the planets landmasses from view is eaten away in a flash of light.

The clone blinks. It stops, looking awkwardly around it. What was it doing? It can't... It can't remember. There was a flash of light, warmth, but before that...?

"Remaining intruder's position detected. Running removal procedure now." It's a robotic voice. The clone notices a hologram in front of it, large cape, and shades of blue. It doesn't notice the large spider construct until it scoops him up off the floor.

"Good," says another hologram. This one is more expressive, its eyes flashing as she oversees the spider removing him from the darkened corridor. "The Heart of Etheria chamber is now safe from interference."

The Heart... That's right, the Clone had been heading for the heart. Big Broth- no, Shadow Prime had required it of him. A last-

ditch effort to... to what? The Clone is not too sure. It feels... It feels like it can finally feel its own feelings for the first time.

Oh, this is interesting, a good if overwhelming interesting.

When Netossa, Frosta and others finally arrive in the clearing, the last of the shadows above them dissipates. The sky glows bright and clear, the light of Etheria's moons a welcome sight for sore eyes. To Frosta's mild disappointment, the remaining Clones have their arms up in surrender, blinking at the likes of Huntara threatening them, formerly chipped Etherians rubbing at necks from which the chips have fallen off, leaving raw scars but, mercifully, unharmed people to greet them. Netossa laughs in delight upon seeing that not a single Shadow Creature is to be seen. Castaspella looks exhausted but happy, as an unknown woman helps her catch her breath. Mermista greets them, making some glib comment about how its nice to see them, or something, and sorry about the boats.

"Where..." Netossa blinks, as she takes in the full extent of the people in the clearing. "Where are Glimmer and Bow?"
She's asking Castaspella, but it's the unknown woman who answers.

"They've gone to check on Adora and Catra with Swiftwind," she says. There's a hint of emotion in the tall woman's voice, something resembling... Pride? Hope? "They'll be fine. I know it."

"Oh Gosh, Netossa! I-" Netossa doesn't have the chance to ask for more explanations as she's crushed in one of Scorpia's enthusiastic hugs.

The main door to the Crystal Castle hangs half open, scorch marks from the blast that forced it open now contrasting darkly

with its surface as full daylight hits it for the first time in months. The woods chirp behind them as the two nod at each other, ignoring the commentary from the winged horse behind them.

Bow's hand fits around Glimmer's with an ease born from too many a battle fought side by side. She has to fight the reflex to immediately teleport as his palm meets hers, but then she relaxes at the feeling of his body warmth, the calluses on his fingers. He's been her rock through thick and thin, helped her grieve when she thought her world lost, as she helped him through his own struggles. The two exchange awkward smiles – giddy with hope, too jaded still to let it grow.

Bow nods again, and Glimmer takes off at a run. He matches her, never letting go of her hand. There's no hologram stopping them this time as they make their way through the Crystal Castle's atrium. The colours inside seem intensified, warmer somehow. Glimmer can't help but let out an uncontrolled giggle. They've been hiding from shadows for so long, it feels strange not to feel them lingering anymore.

"This way!" Bow points at the door Adora and the others left through earlier, and the two are barrelling down the corridor. Everything seems to be sparkling, although that may be the tears of joy in Glimmer's eyes. She sniffs as she rubs them away, not unsurprised to see Bow's eyes similarly wet.

They have to slow to catch their breath around the fourth bend. They stop, hands clutching at stitches in their sides as they huff. Glimmer is ready for a soft bed. Maybe a week of bedrest will do the trick. Bow is giving her shoulder a gentle rub as they start to hear the distant echo of conversation. Glimmer perks up, listening intently.

A low rumble, reminiscent of her childhood. The higher tones of the one who helped keep her sane during her captivity on Horde Prime's ship... And-

A glow bounces off the walls leading to the next bend. Rainbow flecks dance in a prismatic fashion, but none of that prepares her for the radiance of She-Ra rounding the corner.

She doesn't stop to think twice, instantly teleporting to the other group, landing with her arms around She-Ra's shoulders and crying out in delight.
"Adora! Catra! You're both okay!"

Adora stumbles a little but laughs.

"Good to see you too, Sparkles," Catra says, punching her in the arm, prompting her to let go and drop to the floor.

"How did you guys do it?" Bow says from beside her. Looks like he did manage to keep hold through the teleport. Good. "Whatever it was, it worked amazing! Not a single shadow is left, all the chipped people have been freed and the clones are surrendering!"

"That's amazing!" Micah says, helping support a tired but smiling Angella who is resting on Melog's back. She waves.

Glimmer looks at Adora and Catra, noticing that something feels different. Catra arcs a brow, seemingly daring She-Ra to say anything. Adora just smiles a goofy grin and shrinks down to her normal size. The glow of the failsafe is noticeably absent.

"It's over," Adora says. She sounds a little melancholy. She pulls Catra's hand up to her lips. "We get to start afresh."

The blush on Adora's cheeks, the obvious fluster in Catra's body language with her tail fluffing out and cheeks darkening. It doesn't take long for Glimmer to put two and two together.

She'd feel sorry for the pained wince she inflicts on Catra from the intensity of her happy squealing, if only she could think of another way to express her delight.

"Do you think she knew? What her actions did to Etheria?"

It's been weeks now, since Adora and Catra awoke from a prolonged sleep to save the world. There's so much to adjust to, so much rebuilding and stories they're both catching up on. It's still surreal seeing Bow and Glimmer indulging now in public displays of affection, when the last they'd seen before of them had been so distant. Adora's happy for them, but not as happy as she is to be loved by and to love Catra. They both have a lot to work through. Everyone has. Adora thinks back to her catch-up with Mermista and Seahawk, the pair away to spend a week at sea to see some of the new wildlife that's emerged since the freeing of Etheria's magic. Mermista had choice words to say about her time under Shadow Prime.

"She knew," she answers, putting an arm around Catra's shoulders as she joins her out on the balcony. They've both had their fair share of melancholy moments since their old mentor's passing. "She just never cared."

A bemused huff. A shrug. "When did she ever?"

"Tough afternoon with Micah?" Adora can feel how exhausted Catra is today. Her tail is only moving in short flicks, and she's leaning limply into Adora's grasp. She's been better at getting more sleep, especially once they got moved back into Adora's old room at Brightmoon, so Adora's not too worried. They're away to go sleep soon.

"No, actually," Catra says with a warm smile. Adora knows the two have been busy helping Mystacor clean up some of the damage wrought by Shadow Prime's occupation. Catra apparently has a surprising knack for finding the right parts of a magic crystal, with Melog's help. The purple Krytan is purring at their feet, reclined on their back. That can't be comfortable, but they seem happy. "It was good. I just... Micah said something about how much he appreciated my help in fixing things, and I... Wondered."

"That's my Catra, righter of wrongs," Adora teases with a grin. She kisses her cheek before saying in a much softer voice. "I'm so proud to be your girlfriend."

"Ugh you sap!" Catra groans, before standing on tiptoe to wrap her arms around Adora's neck and draw her in for a heated kiss. When it finishes, she whispers, "Say that again."

The balcony becomes a place of laughter and gentle touches. Some time later Adora rejoices in the warmth of Catra in her arms as they sit, Catra now content to purr against her chest as her tail strokes Adora's bicep. Adora turns her gaze to the sky.

The stars are truly beautiful tonight. Adora wonders which one Mara travelled to with Light Hope. Adora is glad the AI is now free of the Crystal Castle, Entrapta confirming with her and Mara's help that the Heart would never again syphon magic from the runestones. It was also nice seeing the Star Siblings again. Hordak, surprisingly, volunteered to help them ferry the newly freed clones across the Universe in some kind of rehabilitation and restitution scheme.

One day, Adora knows, she'd like to go exploring space again, with Catra at her side, and enjoy that peacefulness among the stars. The whispering doubts she's had in her head since childhood aren't totally gone, but they're much rarer, much fainter now. She's gotten better at letting them go, recognising them for the embittered poison left by a woman who could have chosen to be a bringer of light, but chose the darkness instead.

A shooting star darts across the sky. Adora's eyes never leave it as she chooses to make a wish.

The Darkness never truly went away. It just shrunk, turned into a speck of dust so fine it could no longer remember those it had

harmed, those that had called upon it... It couldn't even remember what it felt like to be hungry.

In a golden age that spanned across galaxies, it fell into orbit around the magical planet upon which it came to be. Centuries passed before it awoke from its long slumber. Disoriented and confused, it fell to the ground, landing in a field of tall grasses and floating flowers with a quiet thud in the dead of night. It looked upon the growing plants, reached out to touch the firmness of their form. It blinked up towards the sky, seeing the glow of a few moons, and the twinkling of a billion stars. It shivered... It wanted.

A voice, ethereal and unbound, called out to it. Scared, the Darkness tried to move away. The newcomer, a silhouette bathed in flowing light, brighter than the brightest moon by a hundred-fold, raised its hands.

Stop, it seemed to say. You need not fear me. I want to help.

Doubt burned fiery through the Darkness's being, but also curiosity. It tilted its head, imploring the being of Light to explain.

I want to help you exist without hurting others this time.
This time? Yes, the Darkness thought. This time needs to be different.
And I... I need you, to help me to remember to be selfish sometimes.

The Darkness pondered its response. It didn't like the Light. It felt scary and different, but... The Darkness thought back to it's centuries long slumber. It knew... It knew loneliness. The Light felt lonely too.

Yes, it considered. Maybe it would be good to have a friend this time around. The Darkness stood, and the Light smiled. This wouldn't be easy but... They'd try. What more could they hope for?

FIN.

Chapter End Notes

Writing endings is so hard, and there's a few points in this chapter I hummed and hawed over. I'd love to hear your feedback on it and the story as a whole.
I'm glad to have it done though! Over 28k words exploring my interpretation of what would have happened if Shadow Weaver had gone after the magic of the Heart feels like plenty... And I really wanted to end it on a more hopeful note.

Thanks so much for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!